STUDY BOOKLET · SECOND, EXPANDED EDITION · 10 NOVEMBER 2026 · 30 CHESHVAN 5787

The Vessel and the Witness

Torah Studies from Bereishis to Sukkos

Readings in maamarim and sichos of the Lubavitcher Rebbe and a further Chassidic talk, with essays by Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren: sources in the original, working translations and questions for study

Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren — Torah scholar, researcher and writer

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Prepared in deep partnership and cooperation with Grok and xAI
Not for sale. For study at the table, in the beis midrash and at home.

How to use this booklet

This booklet gathers the strongest material from the Source Citation Index of 9 November 2026 into eight chapters that follow the Torah from Bereishis to Sukkos. Each chapter opens with a short introduction, then gives either an essay, one or more source readings, or both. In this second, expanded edition each chapter then adds commentary, haftarah and Tehillim: Rashi, Ramban, the Midrash and the Talmud, the haftaros and the psalms, in Hebrew with a working translation and a short explanation. Each chapter closes with questions for study.

The source readings present maamarim and sichos of the Lubavitcher Rebbe, and one further Chassidic talk, in their own Hebrew words, taken from the booklets themselves. Every quotation was checked against the file and carries its page. The English under each quotation is a working translation prepared for this booklet, and the “Key idea” summaries are a doorway into the source, not a replacement for it.

Several of the maamarim are unedited transcripts (hanacha bilti mugah) issued by Vaad Hanochos B’Lahak. They are cited as such.

The six essays are by Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren, and are given in his words. Where a passage dealing with current public affairs has been left out, the omission is marked […]. “Egypt, Sodom, and the Raised Hand” comes from his own Grok.com conversation of 24 October 2026. “Egypt and Sodom” carries no byline, so its authorship is marked [to confirm].

Every outside work is credited to its own author or publisher, at the point of use and in full in the bibliography. The markers [to confirm] and [link to confirm] are kept wherever a detail is not yet settled, and where a detail rests on only one source the text says so in plain words. The Hebrew in the commentary sections was checked on 10 November 2026 against Sefaria.

In keeping with the custom of printed Torah material meant for the home, Divine names are written as G-d, L-rd and Hashem in English, and as ה' and אלקים in Hebrew. Please treat these pages with care.

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CHAPTER 1

Beginnings: A Wall of Fire, and Delight at the Start

Bereishis and Noach, in two maamarim of 5742

The year of Torah reading begins twice: with the creation of the world, and with Noach, the first person the Torah calls a tzaddik. The two maamarim in this chapter were said by the Lubavitcher Rebbe on those two Shabbosos in MarCheshvan 5742, and were issued this autumn, 5787, as offprints of Sefer HaMaamarim 5742.

The first reads “Bereishis” as “bris eish,” a covenant of fire, and asks what a wall is for: it protects and it bounds, and in the future Jerusalem will need no wall. The second asks why Noach’s name is doubled at the start of his story, before the flood, and answers that delight can already be present at the start of hard service.

Introduction prepared for this booklet.

SOURCE READING 1.1

A Wall of Fire

מאמר ד"ה בראשית ברא, ה'תשמ"ב

Maamar “Bereishis Bara,” Shabbat Parshat Bereishis, Mevarchim MarCheshvan 5742 (unedited transcript)

Key idea

The maamar opens from the Rebbe Rashab’s maamar of 5678, which cites the Tikkunei Zohar: “Bereishis” is “bris eish,” a covenant of fire. To

explain it, it takes up the promise “I will be for her a wall of fire around” together with “Jerusalem will dwell unwalled.”

A wall does two things: it protects the city from the enemy, and it bounds it, separating inside from outside. Spiritually, it keeps the kelipos from drawing more than their measured portion, and it keeps the inner light within its proper place. In a person’s service “the wall is Torah”: protection through the prohibitions, and limit through keeping the mitzvos in their measure, neither adding nor subtracting, and through dealing with material matters “without heart,” only as much as needed. In the future Jerusalem will need no wall; yet there will be a “wall of fire,” the revelation of the innermost level drawn through its gevurah so that the world is not dissolved. Even now, “unwalled Jerusalem” is mitzvos kept beyond measure, “Your commandment is very broad.”

Summary prepared for this booklet from the source file.

In the source’s own words

English renderings are working translations prepared for this booklet.

> והנה ענין החומה בעבודת האדם הוא כמארז"ל אני חומה זו תורה, וגם בחומה זו ישנם ב' ענינים הנ"ל שמגינה וגם מגבילה כו'

The meaning of the wall in a person’s service is as the Sages said, “I am a wall: this is Torah.” This wall too has the two aspects explained above: it protects and it also sets a limit.

p. נ (PDF p. 6)

> אבל לעתיד פרזות תשב ירושלים, שלא יצטרכו עוד לחומה כו'

But in the future, “Jerusalem will dwell unwalled,” for a wall will no longer be needed.

p. נ (PDF p. 6)

שפרזות תשב ירושלים בעבודת האדם הוא כללות הענין דקיום המצוות באופן שלמעלה ממדידה והגבלה, וכמ"ש רחבה מצותך מאד

"Jerusalem will dwell unwalled," in a person's service, is the general matter of keeping the mitzvos in a way that is above measure and limit, as it is written, "Your commandment is very broad."

p. נא (PDF p. 7)

For discussion

1. When is a boundary a protection, and when is it a limit? Give one example of each from your own week.
2. What does it mean to deal with material matters "בלא לב ולב," without the heart?
3. How can a person live "unwalled," beyond measure, while still keeping the measures of the law?

Cite inline: (the Lubavitcher Rebbe, maamar *Bereishis Bara* 5742, Otzar HaChassidim offprint, p. נ)

Full citation: The Lubavitcher Rebbe, Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson, maamar *Bereishis Bara* (ד"ה בראשית ברא גו'), said at the farbrengen of Shabbat Parshat Bereishis, Mevarchim and Erev Rosh Chodesh MarCheshvan 5742, hanacha bilti mugah (unedited transcript), printed from p. מח, offprint from Sefer HaMaamarim 5742 (forthcoming), issued for Shabbat Parshat Bereishis 5787 (foreword dated 24 Tishrei 5787), Sifrei Otzar HaChassidim, Lubavitch; prepared for print by Vaad Hanochos B'Lahak; Brooklyn, NY: Lahak Hanochos Inc., 2026 (5787) (copyright page); www.lahak.org [link to confirm]; Drive, Laptop Downloads 2026-11-06 folder (ID 1fNxl4_0JJ79V4poWB0eCONu1cg0X3sRW), inside the part01–part04 ZIP archives.

• Unedited transcript (bilti mugah): cite it as such.

SOURCE READING 1.2

Noach, Noach: Delight at the Start

מאמר ד"ה אלה תולדות נח, ה'תשמ"ב

Maamar "Eileh Toldos Noach," Shabbat Parshat Noach, 3 MarCheshvan 5742 (unedited transcript)

Key idea

Why is Noach's name doubled, "נח נח," at the opening of his story, before the flood? The doubled names of Avraham, Yaakov and Moshe come at the completion of their service, and the "rest" (נייחא) for the lower and upper worlds came only after the flood, when "Hashem smelled the pleasing aroma."

The maamar answers through two readings of Noach entering the ark: the ark as the yesod of imma (binah) and as the yesod of malchus. In service these are Torah, which must be learned with real understanding, at full expansion, and mitzvos, which must be kept with complete self-nullification before the King. Both belong to every Jew, to those who sit in the tent and to those in business. With the Baal Shem Tov, the "teivah" is also the word of Torah and prayer, which one must enter and make shine. The doubled name at the beginning teaches that even at the start of hard service, amid concealment, knowing that the descent is for an ascent already brings the delight that will be revealed later.

Summary prepared for this booklet from the source file.

In the source's own words

English renderings are working translations prepared for this booklet.

> אלה תולדות נח נח איש צדיק גו'. וידוע הדיוק בדרושי רבותינו נשיאינו במ"ש נח נח ב' פעמים

"These are the generations of Noach; Noach was a righteous man ..." The precision is well known in the discourses of our Rebbeim on why it says "Noach, Noach" twice.

p. נד (PDF p. 4)

> משא"כ קיום המצוות צ"ל דוקא בתכלית הביטול לגבי רצונו של הקב"ה

Whereas the keeping of the mitzvos must be specifically with complete self-nullification before the will of the Holy One, blessed be He.

p. נו (PDF p. 7)

כי, אע"פ שהעבודה עצמה היא עבודת פרך, וישנם כמה העלמות והסתרים כו', מ"מ, בידעו שהירידה היא צורך עלי', ולפום צערא אגרא

For even though the work itself is hard labor, and there are many concealments and hidings, still, since he knows that the descent is for the sake of an ascent, and "according to the pain is the reward" …

p. נח (PDF p. 8)

For discussion

1. The maamar insists that Torah study needs real understanding, not faith alone. Why is the effort to understand itself a form of service?
2. Why must mitzvos be kept with complete nullification, even by someone who understands their reasons?
3. How can knowing the end of a hard task bring delight already at its start?

Cite inline: (the Lubavitcher Rebbe, maamar *Eileh Toldos Noach* 5742, Otzar HaChassidim offprint, p. נד)

Full citation: The Lubavitcher Rebbe, Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson, maamar *Eileh Toldos Noach* (ד"ה אלה תולדות נח גו'), said at the farbrengen of Shabbat Parshat Noach, 3 MarCheshvan 5742, hanacha bilti mugah (unedited transcript), printed pp. נד–נט, offprint from Sefer HaMaamarim 5742 (forthcoming), issued for Shabbat Parshat Noach, 6 MarCheshvan 5787 (foreword dated "shilhei Tishrei" 5787), Sifrei Otzar HaChassidim, Lubavitch; prepared for print by Vaad Hanochos B'Lahak; Brooklyn, NY: Lahak Hanochos Inc., 2026 (5787) (copyright page); www.lahak.org [link to confirm]; Drive, Laptop Downloads 2026-11-06 folder (ID 1fNxl4_0JJ79V4poWB0eCONu1cg0X3sRW), inside the part01–part04 ZIP archives.

• Unedited transcript (bilti mugah): cite it as such.

FURTHER LEARNING

Commentary, haftarah and Tehillim

The two maamarim open the year. These texts open the Torah and its first haftaros, and set the two Shabbosos beside the psalm of creation.

Hebrew quoted from the texts on Sefaria, checked 10 November 2026. English renderings are working translations prepared for this booklet.

Why the Torah begins with Bereishis

אמר רבי יצחק לא היה צריך להתחיל את התורה אלא מהחדש הזה לכם, שהיא מצוה ראשונה שנצטוו בה ישראל, ומה טעם פתח בבראשית? משום כח מעשיו הגיד לעמו

Rabbi Yitzchak said: The Torah need only have begun from "This month shall be for you" (Shemos 12:2), the first mitzvah that Israel was commanded. Why then did it open with Bereishis? Because of "He told His people the power of His works" (Tehillim 111:6).

Rashi on Bereishis 1:1 · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Genesis.1.1.1

Rashi's first comment asks why the Torah begins with the world and not with the first mitzvah, and goes on to say that the whole earth belongs to the Holy One, blessed be He, who gives it to whom He sees fit. Beside the maamar "Bereishis, bris eish," the beginning is itself a kind of wall: before any single mitzvah, the Torah sets the frame in which every mitzvah stands. The first boundary is not a prohibition. It is a statement of whose the world is.

Noach, Noach: the mention of the righteous

אלה תולדת נח נח איש צדיק. הואיל והזכירו ספר בשבחו, שנאמר זכר צדיק לברכה (משלי י'). דבר אחר למדך שעקר תולדותיהם של צדיקים מעשים טובים . . . יש מרבותינו דורשים אותו לשבח, כל שכן אלו היה בדור צדיקים היה צדיק יותר; ויש שדורשים אותו לגנאי, לפי דורו היה צדיק ואלו היה בדורו של אברהם לא היה נחשב לכלום

"These are the generations of Noach; Noach was a righteous man." Since Scripture mentions him, it tells his praise, as it says, "the mention of the righteous is for a blessing" (Mishlei 10:7). Another explanation: to teach you that the main "generations" of the righteous are good deeds . . . Some of our Rabbis read it in his praise: all the more so, had he lived in a generation of the righteous he would have been more righteous still. And some read it to his discredit: by the measure of his generation he was righteous, but had he lived in the generation of Avraham he would not have been counted at all.

Rashi on Bereishis 6:9 · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Genesis.6.9

Rashi's two reasons for the doubled "Noach, Noach" are both about praise: the mention of a tzaddik brings blessing, and a tzaddik's true offspring are his good deeds. The maamar adds the Chassidic reading, delight already present at the start of hard service. Rashi also brings the dispute about "in his generations," but he opens with praise, and the Torah calls Noach "righteous, whole." In the spirit of Chafetz Chaim care, when we speak of people, even of the great, we lead with the good.

The haftarah of Noach: the oath after the waters

כי מי נח זאת לי אשר נשבעתי מעבר מי נח עוד על הארץ כן נשבעתי מקצף עליך ומגער בך כי ההרים ימושו והגבעות תמוטינה וחסדי מאתך לא ימוש וברית שלומי לא תמוט אמר מרחמך ה'

For this is to Me as the waters of Noach: as I swore that the waters of Noach would no more pass over the earth, so I have sworn not to be angry with you or rebuke you. For the mountains may move and the hills may falter, but My kindness shall not move from you, and My covenant of peace shall not falter, says Hashem, who has compassion on you.

Yeshayahu 54:9–10, from the haftarah of Noach · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Isaiah.54.9-10

The haftarah of Noach takes the oath after the flood and makes it a promise to Israel in exile. The maamar teaches that the rest and delight which came after the flood can be present already at the start of the work. The prophet says the same in the language of love: "My kindness shall not move from you." The kindness is there before the mountains move, not only after.

Tehillim: the psalm of creation

מה רבו מעשיך ה' כלם בחכמה עשית מלאה הארץ קנינך

How many are Your works, Hashem! You made them all in wisdom; the earth is full of Your possessions.

Tehillim 104:24 · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.104.24

Tehillim 104, "Barchi nafshi," is the psalm of creation, said in many communities on Rosh Chodesh; this booklet was prepared on 30

Cheshvan 5787 (10 November 2026), the first day of Rosh Chodesh Kislev. The verse joins the two halves of the chapter: "You made them all in wisdom" is Bereishis, and "the earth is full of Your possessions" is the promise that nothing, before the flood or after it, is outside His care.

Questions for the chapter

1. Both maamarim speak of something that is complete only "in the future." What can be lived now, at the beginning?
2. Torah as a wall, and the ark (teivah) as a word of Torah and prayer: how do the two images of shelter differ?
3. Choose one boundary you keep and one place where you could serve "beyond measure." How do they fit together?
4. Rashi says the Torah begins with creation so that we know whose the world is. How does that knowledge change the way you keep a single mitzvah?
5. Why do you think Rashi opens with the reading of Noach in his praise, and only then brings the critical one?
6. The haftaros of Bereishis and Noach both speak of covenant. What does a covenant give that a wall alone cannot?

CHAPTER 2

The Vessel

Lech Lecha: two journeys, and a soul that needs a body

Lech Lecha opens with a journey, and Chassidus hears two: one from below to above, and one from above to below. The source reading, the Rebbe's maamar of Shabbos Lech Lecha, 10 MarCheshvan 5742, explains how the climb of morning prayer gives the strength for the descent into the day's work.

The essay that follows, Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren's "The Vessel That Holds the Republic," reads the Rebbe's sicha in *Likkutei Sichos* vol. 20 on "Please say you are my sister." Avraham is the soul, Sarah the vessel, and the descent to Egypt is a constraint through which sparks are raised. The essay applies the teaching to marriage and to the family as the first school of a free society. A few lines on contemporary politics are omitted […].

Introduction prepared for this booklet.

SOURCE READING 2.1

Two Journeys

מאמר ד"ה לך לך, ה'תשמ"ב

Maamar "Lech Lecha," Shabbat Parshat Lech Lecha, 10 MarCheshvan 5742 (unedited transcript)

Key idea

The maamar opens with the Alter Rebbe's teaching in Torah Or that Avraham's going had two directions, as "he went on his journeys" is plural. From above to below: Avram, "av ram," a level beyond all thought, goes down to "the land that I will show you," the sefirah of malchus, and

down to the physical land. From below to above, the plain sense: he leaves Ur Kasdim and Charan, his father's house, for Eretz Yisrael.

The descent adds to Avraham, the letter heh of "father of many nations," because giving to someone lower needs a higher power, as a sage needs extra understanding to teach a child. The two journeys depend on each other: the descent draws its strength from a prior ascent. Every Jew inherits both. Each morning one climbs the ladder of prayer, and that climb gives the power to go down into ordinary work in the world. In general, Torah is a drawing down from above and mitzvos are a raising up from below. Through both "walks" now, in exile, we come to the future "והתהלכתי בתוככם," G-dliness seen without garments.

Summary prepared for this booklet from the source file.

In the source's own words

English renderings are working translations prepared for this booklet.

> לך לך מארצך וממולדתך ומבית אביך גו'. ומבאר רבינו הזקן בתו"א שבהליכה זו יש ב' ענינים, כמ"ש וילך למסעיו, לשון רבים, שהם ב' מסעות, מלמטה למעלה ומלמעלה למטה כו'
>
> *"Go for yourself from your land, from your birthplace and from your father's house." The Alter Rebbe explains in Torah Or that this going has two aspects, as it says "he went on his journeys," in the plural: two journeys, from below to above and from above to below.*
>
> p. ס (PDF p. 4)

> ובדוגמת החכם שכשצריך להשפיע לקטן (בשנים או בשכל) ה"ה צריך לבינה יתירה כדי שיוכל להשפיע לו
>
> *Like a sage who, when he must teach a child (in years or in understanding), needs extra understanding to be able to give to him.*
>
> p. ס (PDF p. 4)

ועלי' זו היא נתינת כח שעל ידה נעשית אח"כ הירידה מלמעלה למטה, לעבודה דהנהג בהן מנהג דרך ארץ

This ascent is a granting of strength, through which the descent from above to below then takes place, to the work of "conduct yourselves with them in the way of the world."

p. סב (PDF p. 6)

For discussion

1. Why does going down to teach or to lead need more strength, not less?
2. The order is prayer first, then the day's work. How might the morning's climb change the way one does business?
3. The maamar says both journeys are needed. Which comes more naturally to you, and what would the other look like this week?

Cite inline: (the Lubavitcher Rebbe, maamar *Lech Lecha* 5742, Otzar HaChassidim offprint, p. ס)

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• Unedited transcript (bilti mugah): cite it as such.

ESSAY · ARYEH LEIB THORNE TOREN

The Vessel That Holds the Republic

Likkutei Sichos vol. 20, Lech-Lecha Sicha 1: marriage as kli, soul and body · October 2026

Abstract

This expanded essay analyzes the Lubavitcher Rebbe's Likkutei Sichos, Volume 20, Lech-Lecha Sicha 1 ("Say You Are My Sister"). It presents the Sicha's core ontological teaching—that the soul (Avraham / chochmah)

requires the body (Sarah / binah) as vessel (kli) in order to elevate sparks through the constraint of Egypt—and places it in rigorous dialogue with classical Jewish opinions (Ramban, Rashi, Zohar), modern academic treatments, and the American Founders' republican political theory of the family as "the seminary of the state." Drawing on R. YY Jacobson's reading of the sister-bond as the constant, pre-choice oneness that sustains marriage under pressure, Daniel Elazar's covenantal federalism (the Abrahamic brit as prototype of self-rule and shared rule), and the practical notes of the original shiur materials, the essay argues that the decisive test of any relationship, institution, or polity is whether it enlarges and protects the vessel for holiness and civic virtue or inverts it for personal advantage. Egypt is elevatable constraint; Sodom is structural refusal of partnership. The same distinction governs marriage and the republic.

1. Primary Summary of the Sicha

Likkutei Sichos Volume 20, Lech-Lecha Sicha 1 addresses the episode in Genesis 12:10–20. A famine drives Avraham and Sarah down to Egypt. Fearing that the Egyptians will kill him in order to take his beautiful wife, Avraham asks Sarah: "Please say you are my sister, so that it may go well with me because of you, and that my soul may live because of you."

The surface difficulty is acute. Classical commentators register the tension. Ramban sees an inadvertent but serious sin whose consequences later appear in the Egyptian exile. Rashi focuses on the practical calculation that the Egyptians would spare a sister's husband while killing a wife's. The Zohar (Tazria 52a) records that Avraham relied on Sarah's superior spiritual merit and the protection of angels.

The Rebbe's reading, as taught by R. Ari Shishler and R. Fishel Oster, is not primarily apologetic. It is ontological. Avraham represents the soul—chochmah, the illuminating point. Sarah represents the body—binah, the expansive, gestating, building faculty that receives and forms a vessel. The soul cannot accomplish its mission in the world without the body. The gifts Avraham receives are not mere wealth; they are the concrete

elevation of Egyptian sparks (yeridah for the sake of aliyah). The descent into meitzar (constraint) is the necessary condition for the subsequent ascent "weighed down with cattle, silver and gold" (Genesis 13:1). The episode therefore models the fundamental structure of Jewish service: the soul needs the body as kli; the higher cannot rest without the lower that receives and elevates it.

This is the practical teaching of the Sicha: one must "make a vessel." Holiness does not float free; it requires a prepared, receptive, enduring container.

2. Classical Opinions Analyzed and Critiqued

Three major classical lines may be distinguished:

- **Ramban (practical-ethical)**: Avraham erred. The calculation that protected his life at Sarah's risk was a sin, even if inadvertent, and it sowed the seed of the later exile. Strength: moral seriousness and historical consequence. Limitation: it leaves the Torah's presentation of the episode as foundational largely unexplained.
- **Rashi / midrashic-practical**: The request is a calculated survival strategy based on Egyptian sexual norms. Strength: it takes the plain sense of the verse seriously. Limitation: it remains external; it does not explain why the episode is placed at the beginning of the Jewish people's story.
- **Zohar and Chassidic**: Avraham trusted Sarah's merit. The request is not self-interest but recognition that her spiritual stature would protect both. Strength: it preserves Avraham's integrity. Limitation (addressed by the Rebbe): it still does not fully explain the ontological necessity of the body-vessel.

The Rebbe's contribution is to move from defense to structure. The episode is not primarily about Avraham's moral standing; it is about the irreducible partnership of soul and body. Without Sarah as vessel, Avraham's mission cannot be realized in the physical world. The gifts are the proof that the descent succeeded in elevating sparks. This reading

does not cancel the classical difficulties; it relocates them inside a larger metaphysical framework in which the vessel is primary.

3. Academic Approaches and the Chassidic Response

Modern academic treatments (e.g., Vered Tohar's work on post-biblical expansions of the Sarah narratives) tend to read the episode as patriarchal apologetic: later midrashim and Josephus amplify Sarah's beauty and sexuality in order to defend Avraham while reinforcing hierarchical gender relations. Source-critical readings (e.g., on TheTorah.com) further note the intertextual prefiguration of the Exodus. The academic pshat difficulties are real; the plain sense of the narrative is troubling.

The Chassidic response is not a denial of those difficulties but a reorientation. Once the body is understood as the necessary vessel rather than as secondary or subordinate, the narrative ceases to be a mere defense of the patriarch and becomes the model of how the higher is realized only through the lower. Sarah is not passive object but active binah who builds the house. The "sister" request, far from reducing her, invokes the most constant and unbreakable dimension of the relationship. Academic readings that stop at hierarchy miss the elevation of the vessel itself.

4. Application to Marriage: Sister and Wife, Vessel under Constraint

R. YY Jacobson's essay "My Sister or My Wife?" (drawing explicitly on Likkutei Sichos Vol. 20 and related Chabad sources) supplies the precise marital application.

A spouse is chosen; a sibling is innate. The spousal bond is passionate, fluctuating, and capable of intense drama; it can also cool. The sibling bond is calm, constant, and unbreakable—two halves of one soul (Zohar). When the couple is in "the Holy Land" (times of ease, inspiration, felt connection), the wife-mode predominates. When they enter "Egypt" (periods of constraint, fatigue, external pressure, or internal dryness),

the only reliable bond is the sister-mode: the pre-choice, ontological oneness that does not depend on current feeling.

The practical instruction is therefore twofold:

- In seasons of constraint, deliberately recall and act from the constant sisterly bond rather than demanding the passionate wife-bond that the circumstances cannot sustain.
- Build and protect the vessel. The relationship itself is the kli in which holiness is received and gestated. Actions that enlarge mutual trust, practical partnership, and shared purpose strengthen the vessel; actions that invert roles for personal advantage corrupt it.

The same logic applies to the relationship with the Divine. Song of Songs 5:2 addresses the beloved as "my sister, my bride." In times of felt inspiration one is the spouse; in times of numbness or exile one survives by the sibling bond—the knowledge that holiness is not merely felt but is one's essential nature. The vessel is protected by the constant bond until the passionate mode can be restored.

5. Synchronization with Republican Political Theory

The American Founders understood the family as the first and indispensable seminary of the republic. John Witherspoon: "The family is the seminary of the state; the first school of instruction, wherein we have our tempers formed to virtue or vice." John Adams: "The foundation of national morality must be laid in private families… Our Constitution was made only for a moral and religious people. It is wholly inadequate to the government of any other." James Wilson called marriage "the parent, and not the child of society… a sort of seminary of the republic." Joseph Story enumerated the public goods of marriage: procreation of healthy citizens, education in virtue, peace of society, and the distribution of the whole of society into permanent unions of interest.

This is not pure Lockean contractarianism. The Founders treated marriage as a pre-political institution founded in nature and consent, lifelong for the sake of children and civic education. It is the primary site

in which the virtues required for self-government—self-restraint, fairness, industry, concern for others—are formed.

The parallel to the Sicha is precise. The family is the vessel (kli) in which civic virtue is received, gestated, and transmitted. Just as the soul needs the body, the republic needs the family. Just as Egypt is a temporary constraint that can elevate sparks when the vessel is protected, political pressure and cultural constraint can elevate a people when the family vessel remains intact. Sodom, by contrast, is structural refusal of chessed and partnership; Avraham separates from Lot rather than forming a permanent alliance with it. […]

Daniel Elazar's work on covenantal federalism supplies the further bridge. The Abrahamic brit is the prototype of a political relationship that is both vertical (with the Divine) and horizontal (among partners), combining self-rule and shared rule. The mutual vessel of husband and wife, and of soul and body, is the microcosm of that covenantal structure. Institutions succeed or fail by the same test: do they make and protect a vessel for holiness, or do they invert the relationship for other ends?

6. Contemporary Resonances and the Practical Test

[…]

- Egypt is elevatable impurity: one enters constraint, protects the vessel (the sister-bond, the family, the institution's core mission), and emerges with elevated sparks.
- Sodom is pure refusal of chessed and partnership. One does not form a permanent vessel with it; one separates.

[…]

- Institutions succeed when they prioritize the making of the kli over the extraction of short-term advantage.

The same criterion governs marriage. In periods of constraint the couple does not demand the fluctuating passionate bond; they protect the constant sisterly oneness and continue building the practical vessel of

shared life. When the constraint lifts, the passionate mode can be restored on a stronger foundation.

7. Conclusion

Likkutei Sichos Vol. 20, Lech-Lecha Sicha 1 teaches that the soul needs the body as vessel, that descent into constraint is for the sake of elevation, and that the constant bond (sister) protects the relationship when the fluctuating bond (wife) cannot. Applied to marriage, the teaching is that one builds and guards the kli especially under pressure, recalling the pre-choice oneness. Applied to the republic, the teaching is that the family is the seminary and vessel of civic virtue; without it the Constitution is "wholly inadequate." The practical test in every domain—marriage, institution, polity—is the same: does the action enlarge and protect the vessel for holiness and the common good, or does it invert the relationship for personal advantage? Avraham's descent to Egypt succeeded because the vessel was protected. The contemporary task is to do likewise.

Cite inline: (Thorne Toren, "The Vessel That Holds the Republic," October 2026)

Full citation: Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren, *The Vessel That Holds the Republic: Likkutei Sichos Vol. 20, Lech-Lecha Sicha 1, Marriage as Kli, Soul and Body*, essay, expanded essay, summary deck and document package, October 2026 (Grok Library conversation record of 25 October 2026), Drive, Laptop Downloads 2026-11-06 folder (ID 1fNxl4_0JJ79V4poWB0eCONu1cg0X3sRW), inside the part01–part04 ZIP archives.

FURTHER LEARNING

Commentary, haftarah and Tehillim

The maamar speaks of two journeys and the essay of a vessel. Rashi, Ramban and the haftarah of Lech Lecha add the purpose of the journey, its meaning for the children, and the strength that carries it.

Hebrew quoted from the texts on Sefaria, checked 10 November 2026. English renderings are working translations prepared for this booklet.

"Go for yourself"

להנאתך ולטובתך, שם אעשך לגוי גדול, כאן אי אתה זוכה לבנים, ועוד שאודיע טבעך בעולם

"Go for yourself": for your benefit and for your good. There I will make you a great nation, while here you will not merit children; and moreover, I will make your nature known in the world.

Rashi on Bereishis 12:1 · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Genesis.12.1

Rashi reads "lech lecha" as "go for yourself." The journey that looks like loss is for Avraham's own good: children, and making his nature known in the world. This is the maamar's point in plain words. The descent from above to below adds to Avraham, as the letter heh is added to his name. What he could not become at home, he becomes on the road.

"A sign for the children"

אומר לך כלל תבין אותו בכל הפרשיות הבאות בענין אברהם יצחק ויעקב, והוא ענין גדול הזכירוהו רבותינו בדרך קצרה ואמרו (תנחומא ט), כל מה שארע לאבות סימן לבנים . . . וכלם באים ללמד על העתיד

I will tell you a principle that you will understand in all the coming passages about Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov. It is a great matter, which our Rabbis mentioned briefly when they said: everything that happened to the fathers is a sign for the children . . . and all of them come to teach about the future.

Ramban on Bereishis 12:6 · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Ramban_on_Genesis.12.6

Ramban gives the key to every story in Bereishis. Avraham's descent to Egypt in a famine, the danger to Sarah, the plagues and the departure with wealth all point ahead to the exile and the Exodus, as he explains on 12:10. The sicha read in this chapter's essay takes the same sign in a Chassidic key: Egypt is constraint, and the wealth that comes out of it is the sparks raised there. The father's journey foretells the children's exile, and gives it its purpose.

The haftarah of Lech Lecha: rising, then running

וקוי ה' יחליפו כח יעלו אבר כנשרים ירוצו ולא ייגעו ילכו ולא ייעפו

> *But those who hope to Hashem shall renew their strength; they shall rise up on wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary, they shall walk and not grow faint.*
>
> Yeshayahu 40:31, from the haftarah of Lech Lecha · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Isaiah.40.31

The haftarah of Lech Lecha begins in Yeshayahu 40:27, and this is its first great promise. Notice the order: first "they shall rise up," and only then "they shall run" and "they shall walk." That is the order of the maamar. The climb of morning prayer comes first and gives the strength for the descent into the day's work. Whoever has first gone up does not tire on the road.

Questions for the chapter

1. The maamar says the descent draws its strength from a prior ascent. Where do you see that order in your own day?
2. Why does the Rebbe read the gifts of Egypt as raised sparks and not as mere wealth?
3. What would it mean to "make a vessel" for holiness in your home this week?
4. The essay contrasts the constant "sister" bond with the changing "wife" bond. Where else does a constant bond carry us through constraint?
5. Rashi says the journey was "for your good." When has a move that looked like loss turned out to be for your good?
6. Ramban teaches that the fathers' lives are signs for the children. Which event in your family's story has become a sign for you?
7. Yeshayahu puts rising before running. What is your "rising" before the day's work begins?

CHAPTER 3

The Raised Hand

Lech Lecha: Egypt, Sodom, and the oath of Bereishis 14

After the war of the kings, Avraham raises his hand to Hashem, "Kel Elyon, Possessor of heaven and earth," and will not take a thread or a sandal strap from the king of Sodom. Yet earlier he had left Egypt rich with Pharaoh's gifts. This chapter reads the contrast through two related essays.

The main text is Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren's "Sedom Cannot Claim the Credit" (23 October 2026). It is followed by the survey of classical opinions from the companion essay "Egypt and Sodom" and by the practical section of "Egypt, Sodom, and the Raised Hand." "Egypt, Sodom, and the Raised Hand" comes from Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren's own Grok.com conversation of 24 October 2026. "Egypt and Sodom" carries no byline, so its authorship is marked [to confirm]. One sentence of its survey, on the order of Pharaoh's gifts and the plagues, has been corrected to follow Bereishis 12:16–17. In these essays the Hebrew name "Kel Elyon" is written "Kel Elyon," following this booklet's custom.

Introduction prepared for this booklet.

ESSAY · ARYEH LEIB THORNE TOREN

Sedom Cannot Claim the Credit

Independence, non-domination, and the Abrahamic oath for contemporary covenant bearers · 23 October 2026

Abstract

In Genesis 14, after rescuing Lot from the four kings, Abraham refuses any enrichment from the king of Sodom. He raises his hand to Hashem Kel Elyon, Possessor of heaven and earth, and swears that he will take

neither a thread nor a sandal-strap, lest Sodom claim, "I have made Abram rich." This essay treats the oath as the structural condition of Abrahamic independence. Drawing on Rashi, Or HaChaim, Bereshit Rabbah, Ramban, and the contrast with Melchizedek and Lot, it shows that the refusal preserves sole credit for the blessing with Hashem, seeds later covenantal institutions (tzitzit, chalitzah), and leaves Abraham free to intercede for Sodom itself. The same principle is read through Philip Pettit's liberty as non-domination, Daniel J. Elazar's covenantal federalism, and Yoram Hazony's particularist national order. Contemporary "Abrahams" who stand against systems that invert tzedek u-mishpat must likewise refuse the thread that would allow those systems to claim authorship of their legitimacy or success. The essay is offered for Shabbat Lech Lecha reading.

1. The Oath and the Scene

The narrative is precise. After the war of the four kings against the five, Abraham (still Abram) pursues, recovers the captives including Lot, and returns. Melchizedek, king of Shalem and priest of Kel Elyon, brings bread and wine, blesses Abraham, and receives a tenth of everything. Only then does the king of Sodom speak: "Give me the persons, and take the possessions for yourself." Abraham answers:

> *"I have raised my hand to the L-rd, G-d Most High, Possessor of heaven and earth, that I will take nothing, from a thread to a sandal strap, and that I will not take anything that is yours, lest you should say, 'I have made Abram rich.' For me, nothing but what my servants have used up; as for the share of those who went with me—Aner, Eshkol, and Mamre—let them take their share." (Genesis 14:22–24)*

The raised hand is an oath. The refusal is absolute. He keeps only what has already been consumed. He insists that the three allies who guarded the baggage receive their full portion.

Rashi on 14:23 links the refusal directly to the earlier promise: "And I will bless you" (12:2). That blessing already includes wealth. To accept even a thread would allow Sodom to claim authorship of the enrichment. The

double refusal covers both the recovered spoils and any additional reward from Sodom's treasury. Or HaChaim emphasizes that the raised hand permits no partial acceptance, past or future. The tithe already given to Melchizedek has separated G-d's portion; personal gain from Sodom is categorically excluded.

2. Sequence, Contrast, and the Seeding of Institutions

The order is deliberate. Melchizedek (Shalem, associated with justice and peace) blesses in the name of Kel Elyon and receives the tithe first. Only afterward comes Sodom's offer. Gratitude and recognition go to the true Possessor. The false claim of enrichment is then refused. This contrast is structural, not incidental.

Bereshit Rabbah 43:9 reads the specific objects of refusal as generative. The "thread" merits tzitzit for the descendants (the petil techelet). The "sandal-strap" merits the chalitzah ritual. Further midrashic associations link the refusal to threads of the Tabernacle, tahash coverings, the scarlet thread of the altar, and the sandals of pilgrims. The act is not mere personal asceticism. It plants the institutions of later covenantal life. What is refused from Sodom becomes the material of holiness.

Ramban situates the entire episode within a larger prefiguration. The four kings foreshadow the four empires. Abraham's victory and subsequent refusal of entanglement foreshadow Israel's ultimate independent triumph—recovery of captives and wealth without becoming clients of those empires. The oath is the seed of that independence.

3. Non-Domination and the Capacity to Intercede

The theological-political meaning is non-domination. Abraham can later stand before Hashem and argue for the city of Sodom (Genesis 18:23–33) precisely because he owes the city nothing. His moral voice remains uncompromised. Lot, who pitched his tents toward Sodom and chose the well-watered plain "like the garden of the L-rd, like the land of Egypt," becomes entangled. Abraham refuses the thread and remains free.

This is the republican ideal of liberty as non-domination in biblical form. Philip Pettit defines domination as the capacity for arbitrary interference, not merely actual interference. Freedom requires security against that capacity. Abraham's oath ensures that Sodom cannot later claim credit for his prosperity or legitimacy; there is no residual debt that would allow Sodom to interfere in the narrative of the covenant. The Possessor of heaven and earth alone is the source. The same principle appears in Elazar's recovery of covenant as a theo-political federal partnership: mutual obligation under a higher power that limits arbitrary will. Hazony's particularist national order supplies the complementary insistence that ordered liberty requires a people capable of standing free of empire or anarchy.

The refusal is therefore not isolation. It is the condition that keeps the covenant path open for tzedakah u-mishpat. Abraham is chosen "to keep the way of the L-rd by doing what is just and right" (18:19). Independence from Sodom's enrichment is what makes that vocation possible.

4. Contemporary Abrahams and Global Sodom

Contemporary bearers of the Abrahamic vocation face analogous tests. "Global Sodom" names any institutional, cultural, economic, or political system that inverts tzedek u-mishpat—pride of plenty, institutional inhospitality, selective justice, narrative control—and then seeks to claim credit for the success, relevance, or legitimacy of those who stand against it. The thread and the sandal-strap remain operative categories: the grant that softens speech, the platform that requires managed narrative, the alliance that lets the other side own the story of one's prosperity or influence.

Accepting such enrichment turns Kiddush Hashem into Chilul Hashem. The system can always say, "I made you rich / relevant / safe." The refusal is not anti-wealth and not isolationism. It is anti-compromise and anti-false-credit. Hashem's promise is sufficient. The capacity to do justice remains intact only when the stand itself is not subordinated.

The positive counterpart remains the fairness to the baggage-guards. Aner, Eshkol, and Mamre receive their full share even though they guarded the supplies rather than fighting in the front rank. Later Jewish law (the principle David articulates in 1 Samuel 30) treats those who stay with the baggage as full partners. Contemporary Abrahams must likewise name and compensate those who hold the line—spouses, colleagues, quiet workers—while refusing the king's claim.

5. Synthesis and Close

The oath in Lech Lecha is the condition of the rest of the story. It keeps credit with the Possessor of heaven and earth, seeds the institutions of the covenant, and leaves the covenant bearer free to stand for tzedakah u-mishpat without debt. Republican theory supplies a precise modern vocabulary for what the text already enacts: freedom as non-domination under a higher authority that itself does not dominate. Particularist covenantal order protects the capacity of a people to maintain its own household against both empire and anarchy.

For the Shabbat table the practical question is simple. Who guarded your baggage this week? Give them their share. Whose claim of enrichment must be refused so that only Hashem receives the credit? The oath still holds.

Cite inline: (Thorne Toren, "Sedom Cannot Claim the Credit," 23 October 2026)

Full citation: Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren, *Sedom Cannot Claim the Credit: Independence, Non-Domination, and the Abrahamic Oath for Contemporary Covenant Bearers*, learned essay, expanded long essay and document package, 23 October 2026 (Substack), https://aryehleibthornetoren.substack.com/p/sedom-cannot-claim-the-credit-independence; also https://aryehleibtoren.com/writing/sedom-cannot-claim.html; Drive, Laptop Downloads 2026-11-06 folder (ID 1fNxl4_0JJ79V4poWB0eCONu1cg0X3sRW), inside the part01–part04 ZIP archives.

From the companion essay "Egypt and Sodom" (§§1–3)

Author [to confirm]; files dated 24 October 2026. One sentence corrected to follow Bereishis 12:16–17 (see the commentary section). Full citation below.

1. Narrative Contrast

In Genesis 12, famine drives Abraham into Egypt. Sarah is taken into Pharaoh's house under the sister ruse. Pharaoh "dealt well with Abram for her sake" and gave him sheep, oxen, donkeys, male and female servants, and camels. Abraham leaves "very rich in livestock, silver, and gold" (Genesis 13:2). In Genesis 14, after the war of the kings and the recovery of Lot and the captives, the king of Sodom offers Abraham the recovered possessions. Abraham replies with an oath:

> *"I have raised my hand to the L-rd, G-d Most High, Possessor of heaven and earth, that I will take nothing, from a thread to a sandal strap, and that I will not take anything that is yours, lest you should say, 'I have made Abram rich.'" (Genesis 14:22–23)*

He retains only what has already been consumed and insists that Aner, Eshkol, and Mamre receive their share. The textual contrast is sharp: enrichment is accepted from Egypt and categorically refused from Sodom.

2. Survey of Classical Opinions

Classical commentators offer several interlocking explanations.

Power and agency. Rav Avigdor Miller notes the practical difference. In Egypt Abraham is a vulnerable sojourner under Pharaoh's power; refusal of a royal gift would have been dangerous. After the war he is the victorious party who has restored the captives. He is free to refuse. The Siftei Chakhamim on Genesis 12:13 similarly observes that strategic necessity in Egypt (protecting life through the ruse) is absent in the Sodom episode.

Nature of the gift and of berakhah. The Maharal distinguishes pure blessing from enrichment that arises under distress. Pharaoh's gifts precede the plagues (Genesis 12:16–17) but are kept after them and after the recognition that Hashem intervened for Sarah; they can be read as fulfillment of the promise "I will bless you" (Genesis 12:2). Sodom's offer

comes from the necessity of defeat. Berakhah, the Maharal holds, arrives from blessing, not from trouble. Or HaChaim emphasizes that the raised hand in Genesis 14 is irrevocable and covers past and future, ensuring that credit remains solely with the Possessor of heaven and earth.

Moral character of the source. The Moshav Zekeinim and others note Sodom's extreme tzarut ayin and institutional inhospitality (Ezekiel 16:49: pride of plenty and refusal to strengthen the hand of the poor). Accepting Sodom's goods risked both resentment from the original owners and spiritual contamination. Egypt, while flawed, is not the archetype of inverted justice in the same way. Ramban on the Sodom narrative stresses that the city's wickedness was directed at excluding outsiders and refusing charity precisely because of the excellence of its land.

Scale, timing, and foreshadowing. Some readings in the Siftei Chakhamim distinguish modest gifts received while poor from the enormous fortune offered once Abraham is already wealthy. Midrashic tradition further sees the Egyptian sojourn as prefiguring the later Exodus: the ancestors' enrichment and departure prepare the pattern for the descendants (Bereshit Rabbah 40).

These approaches are not mutually exclusive. Power dynamics explain the possibility of refusal; the nature of berakhah and the moral character of the source explain its necessity.

3. Analysis and Critique

Each classical line has strengths and limits. The power-dynamics reading (Miller, Siftei Chakhamim) is textually economical and practically compelling, yet it underdetermines the explicit reason Abraham gives: the fear that Sodom will claim authorship of his enrichment. The Maharal's distinction between pure berakhah and enrichment under distress captures the theological priority of credit with Hashem, but requires further specification of why Pharaoh's gifts count as berakhah while Sodom's do not. The moral-character reading correctly identifies Sodom's unique inversion of tzedek u-mishpat, yet risks over-generalizing: Abraham later intercedes for the city, suggesting that the

refusal is not total separation but the preservation of an uncompromised voice.

A synthetic reading holds the strands together. The Egyptian enrichment can still be subordinated to the prior divine promise and does not create a lasting claim of authorship. The Sodom offer, by contrast, would allow precisely such a claim. The raised hand eliminates the capacity for that claim.

From "Egypt, Sodom, and the Raised Hand" (§4)

Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren, prepared in his Grok.com conversation of 24 October 2026.

4. Practical Meaning

In practical terms the distinction is between enrichment that can still be subordinated and left behind, and enrichment that leaves a residual claim of authorship.

Egypt-type situations are temporary, constrained, and exit-able: a professional contract under necessity, a one-time grant that does not require ongoing narrative control, institutional support received while under someone else's power that can be departed once the pressure lifts. These may be accepted when the enrichment can still be subordinated to a prior commitment that Hashem is the true source, and when no lasting client relationship is created. Once one leaves, the other party cannot say "I made you."

Sodom-type situations create exactly that residual claim: a platform that demands managed speech in exchange for visibility, a funding stream whose continuation depends on not criticizing the funder, an alliance that lets the other side own the story of one's success or relevance. The practical test is whether acceptance would give the other party standing to claim authorship of one's prosperity, legitimacy, or voice. If so, the thread is refused. The goods may be legitimate by ordinary rules; the claim of credit is not. Refusing keeps the capacity for uncompromised advocacy intact. Accepting converts Kiddush Hashem into Chilul Hashem.

Fairness to those who held the line remains obligatory. Just as Abraham insisted that Aner, Eshkol, and Mamre receive their full share, contemporary work must name and compensate the quiet partners who guarded the baggage. The refusal is neither anti-wealth nor isolation. It is the condition that keeps the stand itself free.

Cite inline: ("Egypt and Sodom," 24 October 2026; Thorne Toren, "Egypt, Sodom, and the Raised Hand," 24 October 2026)

Full citation: Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren, *Egypt, Sodom, and the Raised Hand: Enrichment, Refusal, and the Condition of Covenantal Freedom*, full essay and document package, prepared in his Grok.com conversation "Importance of Sedom Not Enriching Abraham," 24 October 2026 (Grok Library capture of 25 October 2026, Drive Doc 19VsiDSNTHfglB20aocMIk0XrOiVdils0J985RSZ_C6M). *Egypt and Sodom: Why Abraham Accepted Enrichment from Pharaoh but Refused It from the King of Sodom*, learned essay and package, files dated 24 October 2026, author [to confirm]. Both in Drive, Laptop Downloads 2026-11-06 folder (ID 1fNxl4_0JJ79V4poWB0eCONu1cg0X3sRW), inside the part01–part04 ZIP archives.

• "Egypt and Sodom" has no byline and was not found in a captured conversation; its authorship is still [to confirm]. Its package is dated seven minutes before the Raised Hand package, and both build on "Sedom Cannot Claim the Credit."

• In this booklet one sentence of "Egypt and Sodom" §2 is corrected to follow Bereishis 12:16–17: the gifts precede the plagues.

FURTHER LEARNING

Commentary, haftarah and Tehillim

The essays of this chapter weigh Egypt against Sodom. Here the verses themselves are read in order, with Rashi, the Talmud, the haftarah of Lech Lecha and Tehillim.

Hebrew quoted from the texts on Sefaria, checked 10 November 2026. English renderings are working translations prepared for this booklet.

The order of the verses: gifts, then plagues

> ולאברם היטיב בעבורה ויהי לו צאן ובקר וחמרים ועבדים ושפחת ואתנת וגמלים
> וינגע ה' את פרעה נגעים גדלים ואת ביתו על דבר שרי אשת אברם
>
> *And he dealt well with Avram for her sake, and he had sheep and cattle and donkeys, menservants and maidservants, she-donkeys and camels. And Hashem struck Pharaoh and his household with great plagues over the matter of Sarai, Avram's wife.*
>
> Bereishis 12:16–17 · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Genesis.12.16-17

The order of the verses matters. Pharaoh's gifts come first, in verse 16, while Sarai is in his house; the plagues come after, in verse 17. When the truth is known Pharaoh sends Avram away "with all that he had" (12:20), and he goes up "very heavy with livestock, with silver and with gold" (13:2). Avram did not receive the gifts as a reward for the plagues: he received them before and kept them after. For this reason one sentence of "Egypt and Sodom," which had placed the gifts after the plagues, has been corrected in this booklet to follow the verses.

Paying the debts on the way home

> כשחזר ממצרים לארץ כנען היה הולך ולן באכסניות שלן בהם בהליכתו למצרים,
> למדך דרך ארץ, שלא ישנה אדם מאכסניא שלו. דבר אחר בחזרתו פרע הקפותיו
>
> *When he returned from Egypt to the land of Canaan, he went and lodged at the inns where he had lodged on his way down to Egypt, to teach you proper conduct: a person should not change his lodging. Another explanation: on his return he paid his debts.*
>
> Rashi on Bereishis 13:3 · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Genesis.13.3

Avram comes back rich, and goes back to the same inns. He does not move to grander lodgings, and, on the second reading, he pays what he owed on the way down. This is the raised hand in small coin. Before he refuses Sodom, Avram settles every account, so that no innkeeper on the road can say, "I carried Avram when he was poor." Independence begins with paying one's debts.

Malki-tzedek and the order of blessing

> נשבע ה' ולא ינחם אתה כהן לעולם על דברתי מלכי צדק
>
> *Hashem has sworn and will not relent: you are a kohen forever, by the word of Malki-tzedek.*
>
> Tehillim 110:4 · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.110.4

The Talmud (Nedarim 32b) reads this verse with Bereishis 14. The priesthood was to come from Shem, who is Malki-tzedek, but he blessed Avraham before he blessed the Most High, and Avraham asked, "Does one put the blessing of the servant before the blessing of his Master?" So the priesthood passed to Avraham, "by the word of Malki-tzedek." The same care for credit that refuses Sodom's thread also sets right the order of a blessing.

The haftarah of Lech Lecha: the war of the kings

> מי העיר את אברהם להביאו מארם, שהיא במזרח, וצדק שהיה עושה, היא היתה לקראת רגליו בכל אשר הלך: יתן לפניו גוים. מי שהעירו ממקומו להסיע, הוא נתן לפניו ארבעה מלכים וחילותיהם
>
> *Who roused Avraham to bring him from Aram, which is in the east, and the righteousness that he did went to meet his feet wherever he went? . . . He who roused him from his place to journey, He set before him four kings and their armies.*
>
> Rashi on Yeshayahu 41:2, in the haftarah of Lech Lecha · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Isaiah.41.2

The haftarah of Lech Lecha remembers the war of the kings. Rashi reads "who roused one from the east" as Avraham, whose righteousness went before him, and "He gives nations before him" as the four kings delivered into his hand. If it was Hashem who set the kings before Avraham, the victory is His, and its spoils are not Avraham's to take from Sodom. The haftarah says in one line what the oath of 14:22 says with a raised hand.

Questions for the chapter

1. Why is the order of Bereishis 14 (Melchizedek first, then Sodom) part of the meaning?
2. Of the classical explanations of the contrast, which persuades you most?
3. What is the difference between enrichment that can still be "subordinated" and enrichment that claims the credit?
4. Who guarded your baggage this week? How will you give them their share?
5. Why might the Torah tell us that Avram received the gifts before the plagues, and still kept them after?
6. Rashi has Avram return to the same inns and pay his debts. What "debts on the way down" do you still need to settle?
7. The Talmud corrects the order of Malki-tzedek's blessing. Where does the order of our thanks matter?

CHAPTER 4

Remembered, and Bought Before Witnesses

Vayera and Chayei Sarah

"And Hashem remembered Sarah." The Rebbe's maamar of Shabbos Vayera, 20 MarCheshvan 5743, the birthday of the Rebbe Rashab, compares a woman remembered for children with the earth remembered for rain, and teaches that the blessings of mazal are drawn down through service "with all your might," and through love of every Jew.

The next parsha opens with Sarah's passing and Avraham's purchase of the Cave of Machpelah. Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren's "Buying the Cave in Public" (4 November 2026) reads the full-price purchase before witnesses, and Rivkah's kindness at the well. Only the Torah sections are given here; the essay's passages on current public affairs are omitted […].

Introduction prepared for this booklet.

SOURCE READING 4.1

Remembered Like the Rain

מאמר ד"ה וה' פקד את שרה, ה'תשמ"ג

Maamar "VaHashem Pakad es Sarah," Shabbat Parshat Vayera, 20 MarCheshvan 5743 (unedited transcript)

Key idea

The maamar begins from the Rebbe Rashab's well-known maamar on this verse (20 MarCheshvan is his birthday): the Sages compare a woman being "remembered" for children with the earth being "remembered" for

rain. Children, life and sustenance depend on “mazal,” the level of “ayin” above the ordered chain of creation, from which all blessings flow.

Even so, that level is drawn down through service, specifically “with all your might” (בכל מאדך), service beyond measure and limit, which draws a new will from above. Such service also brings true unity among the powers of the soul. The maamar links this to the first maamar of 5643 on unity and the Name Havaye, whose practical form is love of every Jew and the unity of Israel. Since the exile was caused by baseless hatred, its repair is baseless love, and through it comes the main blessing, the true and complete redemption.

Summary prepared for this booklet from the source file.

In the source’s own words

English renderings are working translations prepared for this booklet.

> וה' פקד את שרה כאשר אמר ויעש ה' לשרה כאשר דבר

“And Hashem remembered Sarah as He had said, and Hashem did for Sarah as He had spoken.”

p. ד (PDF p. 4)

> ויש לומר, שהעבודה שממשיכה בחי' מזל היא העבודה דבכל מאדך

One may say that the service that draws down the level of mazal is the service of “with all your might.”

p. ה (PDF p. 5)

> כיון שע"י אהבת ישראל ואחדות ישראל מבטלים את סיבת הגלות, כמבואר בגמרא שסיבת הגלות היתה שנאת חנם, וא"כ התיקון לזה הוא ע"י אהבת חנם כו'

Since through love of Israel and the unity of Israel the cause of the exile is removed, as the Gemara explains that the cause of the exile was baseless hatred, the repair for it is through baseless love.

p. ז (PDF p. 7)

For discussion

1. What is the difference between serving “with all your heart and soul” and “with all your might”?

2. Why would unity among one's own inner powers be connected with unity among Jews?
3. If baseless hatred caused the exile, what would one act of baseless love look like this week?

Cite inline: (the Lubavitcher Rebbe, maamar *VaHashem Pakad es Sarah* 5743, Otzar HaChassidim offprint, p. ד)

Full citation: The Lubavitcher Rebbe, Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson, maamar *VaHashem Pakad es Sarah* ('ד"ה וה' פקד את שרה גו'), said at the farbrengen of Shabbat Parshat Vayera, 20 MarCheshvan 5743, hanacha bilti mugah (unedited transcript), printed pp. ח–ד, issued for Shabbat Parshat Vayera, 20 MarCheshvan 5787 (foreword dated 15 MarCheshvan 5787), Sifrei Otzar HaChassidim, Lubavitch; prepared for print by Vaad Hanochos B'Lahak; Brooklyn, NY: Lahak Hanochos Inc., 2026 (5787) (copyright page); www.lahak.org [link to confirm]; Drive, Laptop Downloads 2026-11-06 folder (ID 1fNxl4_0JJ79V4poWB0eCONu1cg0X3sRW), inside the part01–part04 ZIP archives.

• Unedited transcript (bilti mugah): cite it as such.

• The booklet (p. ז, §ה) speaks of "מזמור קכ"ד" but quotes verses that are Psalm 123 in the standard numbering [to confirm].

ESSAY · ARYEH LEIB THORNE TOREN

Buying the Cave in Public

Witnessed legitimacy and continuity after the Akeidah in the week of Chayei Sarah (Torah sections) · 4 November 2026 (24 Cheshvan 5787)

Torah sections only. Omitted passages are marked […].

The Week's Learning

[…] Daily Chumash for 23 Cheshvan was the third portion (Genesis 24:10–26): Eliezer at the well and Rivkah's excess of kindness. Hayom Yom records the Tzemach Tzedek's answer when accused of rebellion against the government during the Petersburg conference of 1843: a rebel against the government risks death of the body; a rebel against the Kingdom of Heaven risks death of the soul. Which is worse? Rambam's Positive Mitzvah 245 concerns conducting business with clear contracts and

ownership transfer. Tanya (Iggeret HaKodesh, Epistles 29–30) stresses the multiplicity of mitzvot actions and the Oral Torah as crown.

Torah Foundations: Full-Price Purchase before Witnesses

Avraham insists on buying the cave of Machpelah at full price, in public, before the sons of Ches, at the gate of the city. He rejects the offer of a gift. Genesis 23:9: "that he may give me the cave of Machpelah… for the full price he shall give it to me in your midst for a burial possession." Rashi explains "bekesev maleh" as full value, parallel to David's insistence with Aravnah (1 Chronicles 21:22, 24). Ramban on 23:11 notes that even after payment Avraham first takes symbolic possession (hazakah) before witnesses—the merchants and residents at the gate—before burying Sarah. The transaction is recorded so that later claims cannot reverse it.

Different approaches appear among the commentators. Some midrashic voices treat the episode as one of Avraham's tests. Academic readers of the text note the oral character of the ancient contract and the role of Hittite witnesses. Traditional halakhic analysis (Bava Batra and later poskim) holds that payment of money effects kinyan mid'Oraita even from non-Jews; the Sages required additional documentation for security of title. The Rebbe in Likkutei Sichot (vol. 10) stresses that the insistence on full price is not mere commercial scrupulosity; it establishes irreversible, legitimate title in the land. Avraham refuses the gift because a gift can be retracted; a full-price public purchase cannot. The public character of the act is essential.

Midrashic tradition notes three places for which Israel paid full price so that no later claim of theft could be raised: the Cave of Machpelah, the site of the Temple, and the burial place of Joseph. The insistence on clear, public transfer is structural.

[…]

Continuity after the Akeidah and Rivkah's Excess of Chesed

Rashi links Sarah's passing to the news of the Akeidah. Continuity is not automatic. The servant's mission to secure the next generation is the

work of establishing title for those who come after. In the third portion, Eliezer tests for chesed at the well. Rivkah draws water for the camels—more than was asked. Excess of kindness is not the same as unlimited accommodation. It is the surplus that secures the partnership.

[…]

Ger v'Toshav and the Question of Belonging

Avraham presents himself as "ger v'toshav"—stranger and resident—before the sons of Ches. The dual status is not a problem to be solved by assimilation or by exclusion; it is the covenantal condition. Who belongs is determined by consent to the framework and by conduct within it, not by blood alone or by gift.

[…]

Republican Political Theory and Orthodox Sources

Daniel Elazar's work on covenant as the foundation of Jewish political tradition makes the parallel precise. Covenant is not organic hierarchy nor pure contract; it is a morally binding pact among partners that establishes a new framework, dissoluble only by mutual agreement, supported by a transcendent reference. Avraham's purchase is the first formal stake in the land; it is also the political act of establishing standing as "ger v'toshav." Elazar recovers the biblical covenant as the prior source of federal liberty. The American Founding, on this reading, is not the pure product of secular contract theory but a later expression of covenantal partnership.

Eric Nelson's *The Hebrew Republic* argues that early-modern European political thought became less secular, not more, through the Christian encounter with Hebrew sources. Christian Hebraists treated the Mosaic constitution as a model of the perfect republic. Nelson identifies three claims introduced into European theory by this revival: republican exclusivism, egalitarian property measures, and religious toleration. The Torah's polity is national and covenantal at once. Continuity after the Akeidah is the work of establishing title for those who come after.

Yoram Hazony's recovery of nationalism as loyalty to a particular people and its texts, rather than abstract individualism or imperial universalism, sits in productive tension with Elazar. The Torah's polity is particular. The risk is that particularity can harden into domination. The corrective is the public, witnessed character of title.

[…]

David Novak's work on the Jewish social contract emphasizes the thick communal entry into a thinner contractual framework. Rights are not prior to community; they are articulated within it. The covenantal model resists the privatization of religion while preserving the public character of legitimacy.

[…]

Synthesis and Limits

The week of Chayei Sarah is the moment when continuity is secured by witnessed acts: the purchase before the gate, the servant's prayer at the well, the excess of kindness that draws more water than asked. […] The rest is the work of the covenant.

Cite inline: (Thorne Toren, "Buying the Cave in Public," 4 November 2026)

Full citation: Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren, *Buying the Cave in Public: Witnessed Legitimacy, Continuity after the Akeidah, and the Covenantal Republic in the Week of Chayei Sarah*, essay package (Chayei_Sarah_Covenantal_Essay_Package_4Nov2026), 4 November 2026 (24 Cheshvan 5787 as printed), published as "Buying the Cave in Public: Title Before Witnesses", https://aryehleibtoren.com/writing/buying-the-cave-in-public.html; Drive, Laptop Downloads 2026-11-06 folder (ID 1fNxl4_0JJ79V4poWB0eCONu1cg0X3sRW), inside the part01–part04 ZIP archives.

• This sheet and the booklet use only the Torah sections. The essay's passages on current public affairs are left out of this collection.

FURTHER LEARNING

Commentary, haftarah and Tehillim

Vayera and Chayei Sarah are read here beside Rashi, the midrash on the three purchases, the two haftaros and Tehillim.

Hebrew quoted from the texts on Sefaria, checked 10 November 2026. English renderings are working translations prepared for this booklet.

Praying for another

סמך פרשה זו ללמדך, שכל המבקש רחמים על חברו והוא צריך לאותו דבר, הוא נענה תחלה (בבא קמא צ"ב), שנאמר ויתפלל וגו', וסמיך ליה וה' פקד את שרה, שפקדה כבר קדם שרפא את אבימלך

> *Scripture placed this passage here to teach you that whoever asks for mercy for his fellow while he himself needs that same thing is answered first, as it says, "And Avraham prayed . . . ," and right after it, "And Hashem remembered Sarah": He had remembered her even before He healed Avimelech.*
>
> Rashi on Bereishis 21:1 · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Genesis.21.1

Avraham prays for Avimelech's household to be healed and to bear children, and in the very next verse Sarah is remembered. Rashi learns from the order that one who prays for another, while needing the same thing, is answered first. The maamar of Shabbos Vayera 5743 says that love of every Jew removes the cause of exile. Rashi shows that love in its simplest form: praying for another's need before one's own.

The haftarah of Vayera: the woman of Shunem

למועד הזה כעת חיה את חבקת בן

> *At this season, at this time next year, you will be embracing a son.*
>
> Melachim II 4:16, from the haftarah of Vayera · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/II_Kings.4.16

The haftarah of Vayera tells of the woman of Shunem, who made a small room for Elisha and asked for nothing. Elisha promises her a son in words that echo the angel's promise to Sarah, "at this time next year" (Bereishis 18:10, 14). Both women are remembered in the language of the

maamar: a child given from above nature, to those who gave beyond measure. The Hebrew is given as it is read (the keri).

Three places bought at full price

> זה אחד משלשה מקומות שאין אמות העולם יכולין להונות את ישראל לומר גזולים הן בידכם, ואלו הן: מערת המכפלה, ובית המקדש, וקבורתו של יוסף

This is one of three places of which the nations of the world cannot taunt Israel and say, "They are stolen in your hands." These are they: the Cave of Machpelah, the Beis HaMikdash, and the burial place of Yosef.

Bereishis Rabbah 79:7 · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Bereshit_Rabbah.79.7

This is the midrash that "Buying the Cave in Public" cites. It brings a verse for each purchase: Avraham weighed silver to Efron (Bereishis 23:16), Dovid paid Aravnah the full price (Divrei HaYamim I 21:25), and Yaakov bought the field at Shechem (Bereishis 33:19). A full-price purchase before witnesses closes the question of right for good. It is given here as Torah, for study, and not as a comment on any current dispute.

The haftarah of Chayei Sarah: old and advanced in days

> והמלך דוד זקן בא בימים

And King Dovid was old, advanced in days.

Melachim I 1:1, from the haftarah of Chayei Sarah · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/I_Kings.1.1

The haftarah of Chayei Sarah opens with words that echo the parsha: "And Avraham was old, advanced in days, and Hashem had blessed Avraham in all" (Bereishis 24:1). Both old men turn to the same task, continuity. Avraham sends his servant to find a wife for Yitzchak; Dovid makes sure that Shlomo will sit on his throne. The essay calls this continuity after the Akeidah. The haftarah shows that it is the work of every generation's old age.

Questions for the chapter

1. The maamar links the rain and the child to service beyond measure. Why would blessings beyond nature need service beyond measure?

2. Why does Avraham refuse the cave as a gift?
3. Rivkah gives more than was asked. How is that different from giving whatever is asked?
4. Avraham is "ger v'toshav," stranger and resident. Where do you feel both at once?
5. Rashi teaches that one who prays for another is answered first. For whom will you pray this week, in the very thing you need yourself?
6. Why does it matter that Avraham paid in coin "current with the merchant"?
7. The haftarah of Chayei Sarah sets Dovid's old age beside Avraham's. What does each do to secure continuity?

CHAPTER 5

Rachel on the Road

Vayechi, in Likkutei Sichos vol. 30

At the end of his life Yaakov tells Yosef that he buried Rachel on the road to Efras, and Rashi explains why: so that she would plead for her children as they went into exile, and be answered, "the children will return to their border." The Rebbe's sicha, printed in *Likkutei Sichos* vol. 30 and adapted from the talk of Shabbos Vayechi 5746, asks what "deed" earned Rachel that answer.

The answer is that she gave up her own place for children who would one day deserve exile, and so, measure for measure, they are promised return whatever their state. The file is a scan, and its quotations were read from the page images.

Introduction prepared for this booklet.

SOURCE READING 5.1

Rachel on the Road

ליקוטי שיחות חלק ל, ויחי א

Likkutei Sichos vol. 30, Vayechi, Sicha 1 (pp. 236–240)

Key idea

Yaakov tells Yosef (Bereishis 48:7) that he buried Rachel "on the road," near Beit Lechem, and not in the Cave of Machpelah. Rashi explains that this was by Divine instruction, so that when Nevuzaradan led her children into exile she would come out, weep and plead for them, and

Hashem would answer: “There is reward for your deed … and the children will return to their border” (Yirmiyahu 31).

The Rebbe asks why Rashi brings this explanation at all, and what “deed” Rachel did, if she only pleaded. The answer the sicha builds: the burial on the road was not a loss imposed on Rachel for her children’s sake. Their redemption is her own good, and she surely agreed to it and asked for it. By giving up the special merit of lying in Machpelah beside Yaakov, for children who would one day deserve exile, she drew down, measure for measure, the promise that the children will return whatever their revealed state.

Summary prepared for this booklet from the source file.

In the source’s own words

English renderings are working translations prepared for this booklet.

גם יש לדייק בלשון רש"י בתשובת הקב"ה לרחל, "יש שכר לפעולתך נאום ה' וגו'" (ושבו בנים לגבולם)" – ואינו מובן, שלא מוזכר כאן שום "פעולה" של רחל שעבורה מגיע לה שכר ("יש שכר לפעולתך"), כי"א רק שהיא "מבקשת עליהם רחמים"

> *One must also examine the wording of Rashi in the Holy One’s answer to Rachel, “There is reward for your deed, says Hashem” (“and the children will return to their border”). This is hard to understand, since no “deed” of Rachel is mentioned here for which she would deserve a reward, only that she “pleads for mercy for them.”*
>
> p. 236, §א, left column (checked against the page image)

זה שקבר יעקב את רחל בדרך "ע"פ הדבור . . שתהא לעזרה לבני' כו'", אין הכוונה בזה שנגרע מרחל בשביל טובת בני', אלא אדרבה, כיון שזהו גאולת בני' של רחל – ה"ז טובת ואושרה של רחל, ודאי שרחל עצמה היתה מסכמת לכך ודורשת זה

Yaakov's burying Rachel on the road "by the Divine word … so that she would be a help to her children" does not mean that something was taken from Rachel for her children's good. On the contrary: since this is the redemption of Rachel's children, it is Rachel's own good and happiness, and Rachel herself certainly agreed to it and asked for it.

p. 238, §ב, right column (checked against the page image)

וזהו הטעם שהיא הביאה את ההבטחה ד"ושבו בנים לגבולם" – דהיות שהיא ויתרה על מעלת עצמה, בשביל בנים אלו, מצד הקשר העצמי שבינה ובינם (בכל מצב שיהיו), הרי זה ממשיך מלמעלה, "מדה כנגד מדה"

This is why she brought about the promise "and the children will return to their border": because she gave up her own special standing for these children, out of the essential bond between her and them (in whatever state they may be), this draws down from above, "measure for measure" …

p. 240, §ה, left column (checked against the page image)

For discussion

1. Rashi reads Yaakov's words as an answer to a hurt Yosef never voiced. Why might Yaakov explain this only at the end of his life?
2. The sicha argues that what is good for the children is itself Rachel's good. Where, in a family or a community, does giving up one's own standing turn out to be a gain?
3. The promise "ושבו בנים לגבולם" holds "in whatever state they are." What does that ask of us when we look at people who seem far away?

Cite inline: (the Lubavitcher Rebbe, *Likkutei Sichos* vol. 30, Vayechi 1, pp. 236–240)

Full citation: The Lubavitcher Rebbe, Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson, *Likkutei Sichos*, vol. 30 (Bereishis), Vayechi, Sicha 1, pp. 236–240, adapted from the talk of Shabbat Parshat Vayechi 5746 (per the note at the end of the sicha), offprint issued for the hillula of Rachel Imeinu, Kehot Publication Society, Brooklyn, NY, volume published 1992 (per the Vaad L'hafotzas Sichos listing), https://store.kehotonline.com/prodinfo.asp?number=HRE-LS30; text online: https://pnimi.org/likutei-sichot-30-vayechi; Drive, Laptop Downloads 2026-11-06 folder (ID 1fNxl4_0JJ79V4poWB0eCONu1cg0X3sRW), inside the part01–part04 ZIP archives.

• Who issued this offprint (Kehot or another distributor) [to confirm].

• The file is a scan without a text layer, so the quotations were read from page images at 220 dpi.

FURTHER LEARNING

Commentary, haftarah and Tehillim

The sicha on Rachel's burial rests on a verse in Yirmiyahu. Here that verse is read in full, together with Rashi's first comment on Vayechi, the haftarah of Vayechi and a psalm of return.

Hebrew quoted from the texts on Sefaria, checked 10 November 2026. English renderings are working translations prepared for this booklet.

"A voice is heard in Ramah"

קול ברמה נשמע נהי בכי תמרורים רחל מבכה על בניה מאנה להנחם על בניה כי איננו כה אמר ה' מנעי קולך מבכי ועיניך מדמעה כי יש שכר לפעלתך נאם ה' ושבו מארץ אויב

A voice is heard in Ramah, lamentation and bitter weeping: Rachel weeping for her children; she refuses to be comforted for her children, for they are not. Thus says Hashem: Hold back your voice from weeping and your eyes from tears, for there is a reward for your deed, says Hashem, and they shall return from the land of the enemy.

Yirmiyahu 31:15–16 (in some printed editions 31:14–15) · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Jeremiah.31.15-16

These are the verses that Rashi brings on Bereishis 48:7 and that the sicha weighs word by word; they are also read in the haftarah of the second day of Rosh Hashanah. The sicha asks why the answer speaks of "reward for your deed." The verse gives the order: first the weeping, then the command to hold back the tears, then the reason. Her tears are not dismissed. They are answered by a deed already done, when she gave up her own place for her children.

Why Vayechi is a closed parsha

> למה פרשה זו סתומה? לפי שכיון שנפטר יעקב אבינו נסתמו עיניהם ולבם של ישראל מצרת השעבוד, שהתחילו לשעבדם; דבר אחר: שבקש לגלות את הקץ לבניו, ונסתם ממנו

Why is this parsha "closed"? Because once Yaakov our father passed away, the eyes and the hearts of Israel were closed by the distress of the bondage, for they began to enslave them. Another explanation: he wished to reveal the end to his sons, and it was closed off from him.

Rashi on Bereishis 47:28 · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Genesis.47.28

In the Torah scroll Vayechi begins without the usual open space. Rashi gives two reasons: the bondage began to darken the people's eyes and hearts, and Yaakov wished to reveal the end of exile and could not. In the same parsha Yaakov tells Yosef why Rachel lies on the road. The end could not be revealed, but its guarantee could be placed on the way: a mother at the roadside whose tears will be answered.

The haftarah of Vayechi: be strong

> ויקרבו ימי דוד למות ויצו את שלמה בנו לאמר אנכי הלך בדרך כל הארץ וחזקת והיית לאיש

And the days of Dovid drew near to die, and he commanded Shlomo his son, saying: I am going the way of all the earth; be strong, and be a man.

Melachim I 2:1–2, from the haftarah of Vayechi · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/I_Kings.2.1-2

The haftarah of Vayechi again echoes the parsha: "And the days of Yisrael drew near to die, and he called his son Yosef" (Bereishis 47:29). Both

fathers speak to the future at the end of their lives. Dovid's word to his son, "be strong," is the word the congregation calls out when a book of the Torah is completed, as it is at the end of Vayechi: "Chazak, chazak, venischazek."

Tehillim: sowing in tears

הזרעים בדמעה ברנה יקצרו

Those who sow in tears will reap in joyful song.
Tehillim 126:5 · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.126.5

Tehillim 126, "Shir HaMaalos," is sung before Birkas HaMazon on Shabbos and Yom Tov, and opens, "When Hashem returns the returnees of Zion, we were like dreamers." Rachel sowed in tears on the road to Efras, and the psalm promises the harvest in song. The sicha's lesson is the same: what she gave up was not lost. It was sown.

Questions for the chapter

1. Why does the promise to Rachel speak of "reward for your deed" rather than "answer to your prayer"?
2. When does giving up one's own place turn out to be one's own good?
3. How should the promise "in whatever state they are" shape the way we look at another Jew?
4. Yirmiyahu tells Rachel to hold back her tears, and still calls her deed a deed. How can tears be part of a deed?
5. What is closed to you now that you trust will one day be opened?
6. Dovid tells his son "be strong, and be a man." What would you say to the next generation in one sentence?

CHAPTER 6

Let My People Go That They May Serve Me

Shemos: the Exodus as a story of freedom for service

"Send forth My people, that they may serve Me" is said six times in Shemos. Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren's essay (12 Tishrei 5787, 23 September 2026) holds that this is the whole sentence of biblical liberty: cherus, freedom, is completed only within bris, the covenant of Sinai.

The essay traces how the Exodus became the founding story of the American republic, weighs the political theorists and historians with care, and gives a voice to those who sang the Exodus in slavery. Its section on 12 Tishrei, between Yom Kippur and Sukkos, applies the lesson to the Shabbos table. The essay's three applications to current affairs are omitted […].

Introduction prepared for this booklet.

ESSAY · ARYEH LEIB THORNE TOREN

Let My People Go That They May Serve Me

The Exodus as political archetype (Topic 21, The Hebrew Bible in the United States) · 12 Tishrei 5787 (23 September 2026), Yerushalayim

> *"We are assured by covenant that any wide-ranging effort and labor pursued wisely and with friendship is never fruitless."*
> *— Hayom Yom, 12 Tishrei*

I. Thesis: Liberty For, Not Merely From

The most cited political sentence in the Book of Exodus is not a slogan of exit. It is a purpose clause.

"Send forth My people, that they may serve Me."

שַׁלַּח אֶת־עַמִּי וְיַעַבְדֻנִי

(Exodus 7:16; 8:1; 8:20; 9:1; 9:13; 10:3)

Six times the refrain returns. Pharaoh hears it as a demand for labor reallocation. Israel will later hear it as the grammar of *cherut*. The Mekhilta and Ramban insist on the same point the American founders only half grasped and the later republic has repeatedly forgotten: biblical liberty is not *hefkerut*—ownerless license—but release into a higher service. The people are not extracted from Egypt so that they may dissolve into the wilderness. They are extracted so that they may stand at Sinai, answer *na'aseh ve-nishma*, and become a kingdom of priests and a holy nation.

That is Topic 21 of this series. The Exodus is the master narrative of the American founding. It is also the most dangerous narrative in the American inventory, because a people that remembers only the departure and forgets the destination will baptize conquest, confuse charisma with covenant, and call domination by the name of freedom.

The claim of this essay is therefore double. First: the Exodus supplied the American republic with its most durable political typology—Pharaoh and Moses, sea and wilderness, lawgiving after deliverance. Second: Orthodox Jewish theology, read with republican political theory rather than against it, recovers what the typology loses when it is detached from Sinai. *Cherut* is realized only within *brit*. Negative liberty—the absence of a master's whip—is the necessary first movement. Positive liberty—the capacity to govern oneself under law one has received and accepted—is the second. Philip Pettit's liberty as non-domination is closer to the biblical grammar than Isaiah Berlin's clean split, but even Pettit cannot supply what the Torah supplies: a Lawgiver who is not a faction, a covenant that binds the sovereign as well as the citizen, and a prophetic office that functions as institutional critique.

Today is 12 Tishrei 5787. Kapparah was sealed two days ago. Sukkot begins Friday night. Between them a people does not wait. It builds. The day's Chitas already refuses vacation theology: Vezot HaBerakhah assigns

Zevulun to the sea and Yissachar to the tent, Gad to expansion—tribes leaving the wilderness with work in their hands, not with souvenirs of the exit. Tehillim 66–68 makes the Exodus a public liturgy: "Come and see the works of G-d." Hayom Yom for this date promises that wide-ranging labor, pursued wisely and with friendship, is never fruitless. The Exodus, read on this day, is not a museum piece about 1776. It is the architecture of the interval between judgment and dwelling.

II. Colonial and Founding Typology: Pharaoh, Moses, and the Proposed Seal

The American appropriation did not begin with Jefferson's committee. It began on water.

John Winthrop's 1630 *Modell of Christian Charity*, preached aboard the Arbella, already recast the Atlantic crossing as an Exodus and the Massachusetts covenant as a new Sinai. The errand into the wilderness was not tourism. It was typology. Sacvan Bercovitch later named the mechanism: the Puritans did not merely admire Israel; they claimed to *be* Israel in figural fulfillment. That claim is theologically false and politically potent. It is the seed of both American covenantal seriousness and American imperial inflation.

By 1776 the typology had hardened into revolutionary rhetoric. The *Pennsylvania Magazine* compared George III to Pharaoh. Thomas Paine, in *Common Sense*, wrote of "the same tyranny which drove the first emigrants from home," and elsewhere of rejecting "the hardened, sullen tempered Pharaoh of England for ever." John Adams wrote Abigail in May 1776 that he had heard a sermon drawing "a Parallel between the Case of Israel and that of America, and between the conduct of Pharaoh and that of George." James P. Byrd has shown that Exodus 15—the Song of the Sea—was among the most cited biblical chapters of the Revolutionary War. The waters close over the chariots; the people sing; the republic is born on the far shore. George Washington, writing after independence to the Hebrew Congregation of Savannah, named "the same wonder-working Deity, who long since delivering the Hebrews from their Egyptian

Oppressors planted them in the promised land—whose providential agency has lately been conspicuous in establishing these United States." The typology had become the republic's own account of itself.

The most revealing artifact is the one Congress declined. Benjamin Franklin proposed, for the Great Seal, Moses standing on the shore extending his hand over the sea, Pharaoh overwhelmed in an open chariot, and the motto *Rebellion to Tyrants is Obedience to G-d*. Jefferson proposed the Israelites in the wilderness, led by cloud and fire. Congress chose the eagle. The rejected images remain the truer confession of what the founders thought they were doing.

Rabbi Dr. Stuart Halpern, speaking with David Barton at the Hart Senate Building on 29 July 2026 under the auspices of Yeshiva University's Straus Center and the Museum of the Bible, restated the point with useful precision: the Exodus gave the founders a template for imagining their project as a people "freed from tyranny not to wander without direction, but to build a shared life around lasting truths." The Jewish Chronicle, on 30 March 2026, recovered the same Franklin seal and the same Adams letter for a contemporary audience still hungry for origin stories. The hunger is not the problem. The problem is which half of the verse we quote.

"Let My people go" is only half the sentence.

III. The Orthodox Reading: Cherut Within Brit

The Torah's own politics of the Exodus is more severe, and more republican, than the patriotic sermon.

Ramban on Exodus 6 and 19 treats the departure as incomplete until Sinai. Physical extraction without law is a change of masters, not a change of condition. The Mekhilta on *Bo* and *Yitro* already knows that *avadim hayinu* is not finished by the sea. It is finished when the former slaves accept a yoke that is not Pharaoh's. The Talmud (Avodah Zarah 2b–3a; Shabbat 88a) records the midrash that the mountain was held over their heads—*kafah aleihem har kegigit*—and also the counter-tradition of

na'aseh ve-nishma as anticipatory consent. The two midrashim are not a contradiction to be solved. They are the biblical statement of the problem every republic faces: how can a people be bound by a law it did not author, and how can that binding be freedom rather than new slavery?

Orthodox theology answers without embarrassment. The Lawgiver is not a party. The covenant is not a contract among equals that may be dissolved when inconvenient. It is a *brit*—initiated from above, answered from below, renewed in every generation (Deuteronomy 29:13–14: "not with you alone… but with him who is not here today"). That last clause is the most republican sentence in Deuteronomy. It binds the unborn. […]

Rambam, *Hilkhot Melakhim* 1:1–3 and *Hilkhot Teshuvah*, and the *perek ha-melekh* of Deuteronomy 17:14–20, complete the architecture. Kingship is optional, hedged, and literate: the king must write his own copy of the Torah and read it all his days, "that his heart may not be lifted up above his brothers." Nathan before David is judicial review in narrative form. The prophet is not a chaplain. He is an institution.

This is why *cherut* is not Berlin's negative liberty. Absence of the taskmaster is the first plague-cycle's achievement. The second achievement is Sinai. A people that stops at the sea will wander until it demands a calf. A people that stops at Sinai without the wilderness will treat law as magic. The Torah insists on both movements: departure *and* service, extraction *and* constitution, *geulah and ol malchut shamayim*.

Chassidic reading sharpens rather than softens the point. The Alter Rebbe in Tanya treats the Exodus as the archetype of the soul's departure from the *klimot* of Egypt—constraint, narrowness, the *meitzar*—into the service of the Infinite. The Rebbe, Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson, spoke of the United States as *malchut shel chesed*, a kingdom of kindness in which Torah life could be built without the old European boot. That is not a blank check for American exceptionalism. It is a precise theological compliment with a precise limit: America is a vessel. Zion remains the center. Isaiah 60, which is Topic 22 of this series, will not permit the geography to be inverted.

IV. Republican Theory: Walzer, Berlin, Pettit, Lutz—and the Honest Caveat

Michael Walzer's *Exodus and Revolution* (1985) remains the cleanest political reading of the book in English. His triad is justly famous: wherever you live, it is probably Egypt; there is a better place, a promised land; the way there is through the wilderness, and you get there only by marching together. Walzer recovered what sermons flatten: Exodus is not a miracle story that excuses the marcher from politics. It is a politics that requires organization, endurance, law, and the refusal of both slavery and golden-calf sovereignty.

Isaiah Berlin's 1958 distinction between negative and positive liberty maps onto the two halves of the verse with uncomfortable accuracy. Negative liberty is the broken whip. Positive liberty is the received Torah. Berlin feared positive liberty because, in its modern forms, it becomes the excuse by which commissars and Jacobins force men to be free. He was not wrong about the danger. He was incomplete about the source. The Torah's positive liberty is not the General Will. It is a written law that binds the ruler, a prophetic office that can say "you are the man," and a calendar that forces the powerful to rest. That is not Rousseau. It is Deuteronomy.

Philip Pettit's republicanism—liberty as non-domination rather than non-interference—is the closest secular cousin. A slave with a kind master still lacks liberty, because he lives at another's pleasure. Exodus agrees. Pharaoh's later offers—sacrifice in the land, go without the children, go without the flocks—are the politics of domination that keeps the form of release while retaining the power to recall. "Not a hoof shall remain" (Exodus 10:26) is the biblical refusal of partial emancipation. Non-domination requires that the former master lose the capacity to interfere arbitrarily, not merely that he refrain today.

Donald S. Lutz's 1984 study in the *American Political Science Review* is the statistic everyone quotes and almost no one reads. Lutz and Charles Hyneman examined 916 public political writings from 1760 to 1805,

drawn from a larger pool of some 15,000 items. In that corpus the Bible accounted for roughly 34 percent of citations, ahead of Montesquieu, Blackstone, and Locke. Deuteronomy was the single most cited book. That finding is real. It is also, as Warren Throckmorton restated on 23 April 2026, routinely abused. Lutz himself noted that reprinted sermons accounted for the bulk of biblical citations; remove the sermons and the Bible's share falls to about 8.5 percent. Lutz also excluded private correspondence. David Barton and his school treat the 34 percent as proof that "the Constitution is based on Deuteronomy." Baptist News Global (2024) and Throckmorton are right to call that a distortion.

The honest position is neither Barton nor the sneer. The Bible was the moral grammar of a culture that also read Locke, Montesquieu, and Blackstone. Covenant supplied the language of obligation, limited power, and higher law. Enlightenment institutional design supplied separation of powers, representation, and the mechanics of amendment. The American founding is a convergence, not a proof-text. Topic 23 of this series—Deuteronomic constitutionalism—will take the institutional half further. Topic 21 must insist on the narrative half: before there is a *perek ha-melekh,* there is a people that knows what a Pharaoh is.

V. The Critique That the Text Itself Demands

A typology this powerful will be abused. It was.

The same Exodus that taught colonists to resist George III taught other Americans to read the continent as Canaan and its inhabitants as nations to be dispossessed. Winthrop's city on a hill became Manifest Destiny. The promised-land metaphor, detached from the Torah's own laws of the *ger* and from Amos 9:7—"Are you not like the children of the Cushites to Me, O children of Israel?"—underwrote expansion that the prophets would have named as theft. Orthodox exegesis has always possessed the internal check. American preaching often preferred the conquest narratives without the *ger* commandments, which appear some thirty-six times in the Torah precisely so that a redeemed people will not become Pharaoh in its turn.

The more faithful American reading of Exodus was not the planter's. It was the slave's.

Frederick Douglass's 1852 "What to the Slave Is the Fourth of July?" remains the most devastating use of the founders' own Bible against the founders' own practice. Albert Raboteau and Eddie Glaude have documented the double hermeneutic: the white pulpit cast America as Israel; the enslaved cast America as Egypt and themselves as the people waiting on the far side of a sea that had not yet split. The spirituals—"Go Down, Moses," "Didn't My L-rd Deliver Daniel"—are not folk decoration. They are political theology. They keep the verse whole. Liberty is for service of the true Master, not for a new plantation with a different flag.

Here Orthodox particularism must speak plainly. Kinship with the oppressed is real; dissolution of the covenant people into a generic category of "the oppressed" is not. The Haggadah's "in every generation they rise against us" and the spiritual's "Go Down, Moses" rhyme. They do not merge. Israel remains Israel. The land remains the land. The *ger* remains the *ger*—to be loved, not erased, and not installed as a replacement Israel. Topic 29 will treat American Zionism and the test of particular sovereignty. Topic 21 only needs the warning: an Exodus that forgets Sinai becomes either a calf or a conquest.

Leon Kass, reading Exodus as a founding document of peoplehood, asked whether a long-established republic still knows what defines and unifies it. Eran Shalev's *American Zion* mapped how Hebrew republican imagery entered early American political culture with a seriousness later textbooks flattened into "Judeo-Christian values." Both warnings stand in 5787. A republic that uses Exodus as costume will not survive contact with a real Pharaoh.

VI. 12 Tishrei 5787: From Judgment to Dwelling

Two days ago was Yom Kippur. Friday night is Erev Sukkot. Last Shabbat was Haazinu, the song that places heaven and earth as witnesses against a people that will grow fat and forget. The interval is not empty.

Exodus is the map of that interval. The sea is behind. The mountain is ahead. The wilderness is the work. *Cherut* that stops at the shore is a holiday. *Cherut* that walks is a constitution.

The application is not ornamental. […]

Fourth, to the table. The Haggadah already taught children that we were slaves and that we were taken out in order to serve. Between Yom Kippur and Sukkot the lesson is the same in a different season: judgment has been sealed; now we build a dwelling that can hold Presence. A father who wants his children to know what liberty is cannot teach them only that Pharaoh was wrong. He must teach them whom we serve when Pharaoh is gone.

Pittsburgh forged the habit of making things that bear weight. Jerusalem teaches that the thing to be made is a dwelling, not a monument to the exit. The steel and the stone are not two homelands competing. They are two pedagogies of the same verse.

VII. Conclusion: The Verse Kept Whole

Topic 21 is not a claim that America is Israel. That claim is idolatry, and the prophets already forbade it. Topic 21 is the claim that the American republic learned to speak of tyranny, consent, wilderness, and lawgiving in a Hebrew accent, and that the accent is still the best grammar it has for saying what liberty is for.

Let My people go—that they may serve Me.

Not that they may wander.
Not that they may conquer in My Name without My law.
Not that they may become a new Pharaoh with better pamphlets.
That they may serve.

Walzer is right that the way is through the wilderness and that no one arrives alone. Berlin is right that positive liberty can become a new whip. Pettit is right that non-domination is the name of the thing the slave lacks even when the master smiles. Lutz is right that the Bible saturated the public language of the founding, and Throckmorton is right that sermons

inflated the percentage. Douglass is right that a Fourth of July which leaves a people in chains is a liturgy against itself. Amos is right that Israel is not licensed by election to treat other nations as disposable. Ramban is right that there is no Exodus without Sinai. The Rebbe is right that a kingdom of kindness can be a vessel. Isaiah is right that the light the nations walk by rises on Zion, not on the Potomac.

The founders proposed Moses on the seal and accepted the eagle. The eagle is a fine bird. It does not split seas and it does not give law. A republic that wishes to remain free will need both images: the bird that will not be caged, and the prophet who will not let the people forget why they left the house of bondage.

Topic 22 will take up Isaiah 60 and the midrash that the final light is Jerusalem's. Topic 23 will take up Deuteronomy as constitution. Topic 24 will take up the Maccabees as the discipline of resistance. The series is one argument in numbered rooms. This room's sentence is short enough to teach a child and hard enough to judge a nation.

Liberty is for service.
Service is under covenant.
Covenant is how a people dwells.

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• The booklet chapter leaves out the essay's three applications to current affairs in §VI.

FURTHER LEARNING

Commentary, haftarah and Tehillim

The essay holds that freedom is completed in covenant. These texts give the same teaching in the words of the Torah, Rashi, Pirkei Avos, the haftarah of Shemos and Hallel.

Hebrew quoted from the texts on Sefaria, checked 10 November 2026. English renderings are working translations prepared for this booklet.

The merit of the Exodus is Sinai

וששאלת מה זכות יש לישראל שיצאו ממצרים

And as for your asking, what merit do the Jewish people have that they should go out of Egypt? I have a great purpose in this going out, for they are destined to receive the Torah on this mountain at the end of three months after they leave Egypt.

Rashi on Shemos 3:12 · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Exodus.3.12

At the burning bush Moshe asks, "Who am I?" and, as Rashi reads it, "What merit does Israel have to be redeemed?" The verse answers: "When you bring the people out of Egypt, you will serve Hashem on this mountain" (Shemos 3:12). Rashi turns the purpose into the merit. This is the essay's whole sentence of liberty, "Send forth My people, that they may serve Me," said already at the bush, before the first plague.

Engraved, and free

אל תקרא חרות אלא חרות, שאין לך בן חורין אלא מי שעוסק בתלמוד תורה

Do not read charus, "engraved," but cherus, "freedom": for there is no free person except one who occupies himself with the study of Torah.

Pirkei Avos 6:2 · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Pirkei_Avot.6.2

The verse speaks of the Tablets: the writing of G-d, charus, "engraved" on the tablets (Shemos 32:16). The Mishnah reads the same letters as cherus, freedom; the two words are spelled alike, which is why the Hebrew above looks the same twice. The essay says that cherus is completed only within

bris. The Mishnah says it in one image: freedom is engraved, cut into stone, and the one who learns Torah carries it with him.

The haftarah of Shemos: root, bud and fruit

> הבאים ישרש יעקב יציץ ופרח ישראל ומלאו פני תבל תנובה
>
> *In days to come Yaakov shall take root; Israel shall bud and blossom, and they shall fill the face of the world with fruit.*
>
> Yeshayahu 27:6, the opening of the haftarah of Shemos (Ashkenazi custom) · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Isaiah.27.6

Shemos begins with the descent into bondage, and its haftarah begins with roots. Before the flower and the fruit there is a root, and a root grows in the dark. The haftarah teaches us to read the bondage of Egypt as a planting, whose fruit will one day fill the world.

Questions for the chapter

1. Why does the Torah insist on the purpose clause, “that they may serve Me”?
2. How do the two midrashim of Sinai, the mountain held overhead and “na’aseh ve-nishma,” fit together?
3. What does the essay mean by “an Exodus that forgets Sinai becomes either a calf or a conquest”?
4. How will you teach a child whom we serve when Pharaoh is gone?
5. Rashi says the merit of the Exodus was the Torah still to come. Can a purpose not yet reached be a merit now?
6. Why would freedom need to be “engraved” rather than written in ink?
7. Where in your life do you see a root growing in the dark?

CHAPTER 7

A People Stands, Then a Leader Walks

Nitzavim–Vayeilech and the eve of Rosh Hashanah

"You are standing today, all of you, before Hashem your G-d." Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren's essay, written in Jerusalem on 21 Elul 5786 (3 September 2026), reads Nitzavim and Vayeilech as one movement of the covenant: a people is assembled, taught to return, set before life and good, and then handed the Torah and the song as witnesses while Moshe walks on.

Two source readings from Erev Rosh Hashanah follow. In the farbrengen of 29 Elul 5737 the Rebbe draws a lesson from Rosh Hashanah falling on a Tuesday, the day of "good to Heaven and good to people." In two maamarim of Erev Rosh Hashanah 5736 and 5737 he asks why the shofar is not sounded when Rosh Hashanah falls on Shabbos, and what the Shabbos itself accomplishes.

Introduction prepared for this booklet.

ESSAY · ARYEH LEIB THORNE TOREN

A People Stands, Then a Leader Walks

Nitzavim–Vayeilech as one bris: assembly, return, vocation and transmission (Devarim 29:9–31:30) · 21 Elul 5786 (3 September 2026), Jerusalem

In Eretz Yisrael the Selichot of Elul have already begun. Many communities outside the Land will open Leil Selichot on Motzaei this Shabbat. The King is in the field. The shofar has been sounding since the first of the month. This essay is written from Jerusalem on the twenty-first of Elul, two days before the Shabbat of Nitzavim–Vayeilech, eight days before the coronation of the year.

I. Atem nitzavim hayom kulchem: A People Stands, Then a Leader Walks

The combined parsha of Nitzavim–Vayeilech is not two weekly readings taped together because the calendar is short. It is one motion of the berit, spoken on the plains of Moav in the last hours of Moshe Rabbeinu's life, and it always falls — whether joined or split — on the Shabbat before Rosh Hashanah. The Alter Rebbe, in Likkutei Torah on Nitzavim, hears in the word hayom the grammar of the Day of Judgment itself: "this day" is the day on which all Israel stands before the Name. The Lubavitcher Rebbe, developing that reading in Likkutei Sichos (vol. 24, pp. 188–196), insists that the standing is not a crowd's accident. It is the posture in which a people becomes, again, a people before Him. Then the Torah turns the page. Vayeilech Moshe — Moshe went. A people that has learned how to stand must learn how to be led by someone else, how to hear Torah without the first teacher in the room, how to gather itself in hakhel when the original voice is gone.

That is the architecture of this week. Nitzavim assembles. Vayeilech transmits. Between the assembly and the transmission sits the engine of the whole: teshuvah, the return that Devarim 30 writes as both command and promise. "Choose life" is not a slogan pasted onto the end of Nitzavim. It is the vocation of the klal that has stood, that will stray, that can come back, and that must walk into the Land without Moshe.

Rashi opens Nitzavim by teaching that Moshe assembled Israel on the day of his death in order to bring them into the covenant. The juxtaposition with Ki Tavo's tochacha is not cruelty. When Israel heard the ninety-eight curses, their faces paled: Who can stand against these? Moshe began to calm them: you are standing today; you have provoked the Omnipresent many times, and He has not made an end of you. Hayom is like the day that darkens and then shines again. The curses and the sufferings, Rashi says, establish you and set you standing before Him. Standing is still possible, and standing is the form of the berit.

Ramban reads the same opening as readiness: you are standing and prepared before G-d to enter His covenant — gathered to receive the Torah in its interpretation, or standing before the Ark. The berit here is oath and imprecation, alah, because the first covenant at Sinai had not yet bound them under the full weight of curse. After the golden calf and after Baal Peor, Moshe will not leave them with a treaty that a private heart can quietly decline. Ibn Ezra parses rasheichem shivteichem as "your heads, the heads of your tribes." Ramban hears a generalization that then specifies: heads and tribes, then elders and officers who are the heads, then every man of Israel, then the children, the women, the ger inside the camp, from the woodchopper to the water-drawer. The list is not decorative. It is the peoplehood of the oath. No rank is a private exemption. No low station is an excuse to be missing.

The Rebbe, in Likkutei Sichos vol. 2 (pp. 398–400), takes the ten categories of the opening verses as the condition of Rosh Hashanah's covenant. A berit that is to survive the collapse of feeling must be made while love is still strong, by a people that has become, against the grain of rank, truly one. Logic says a tribal head and a water-drawer occupy different worlds. The avodah of Elul is to refuse that logic long enough to stand together. When Jews give themselves beyond calculation, G-d gives Himself beyond calculation. That is the inner structure of Atem nitzavim hayom kulchem on the Shabbat before the coronation.

Daniel J. Elazar mapped biblical berit as neither pure contract nor pure status: a morally binding relationship under a transcendent standard, distributing the people into families, tribes, and offices without letting any single center swallow the whole. Nitzavim is that federal people on its feet. Heads are named first, which is not flattening. The woodchopper is named last, which is not a caste. Both stand lifnei Hashem Elokeichem. The klal is not a mass and not a board of directors. It is an assembly of ranks under higher law.

Rabbi Joseph B. Soloveitchik, in the distinction that runs through Kol Dodi Dofek, named two covenants that Israel actually lives. There is a berit goral, a covenant of fate: the shared exposure of a people who did

not choose one another and cannot resign from one another, the "those who are not here this day" already bound by what will befall the camp. And there is a berit yeud, a covenant of destiny or purpose: the freely accepted task of becoming a holy people, the work that a generation can refuse. Nitzavim holds both in one standing. The woodchopper and the unborn are in the goral whether they like it or not. The heart that turns away this day is refusing the yeud while still standing inside the goral. Elul 5786, with Selichot already in the synagogues of the Land and the shofar already in the morning air, is the season in which fate will not be denied and destiny will not be postponed. We stand because we are this people. We return because standing is not yet the whole of the avodah.

Then Moshe walks. The second parsha does not cancel the first; it completes it. A people that only stands, and never learns to walk after its teacher, has not yet become transmissible. Vayeilech is succession, hakhel, Torah and song as witnesses, and a prediction of straying that is not permitted to become despair. The combined reading of 23 Elul is one sentence: you are all standing this day — and your leader is already going — so that the covenant can outlive the man who taught it.

II. The Covenant with Those Here and Those Not Here

"Not with you alone do I make this covenant and this oath, but with those who are standing here with us this day before the L-rd our G-d, and with those who are not here with us this day" (Devarim 29:13–14). Rashi, following the Tanchuma, will not let the second clause collapse into absentees. Verse 10 has already said that all of you are standing. "Those who are not here" are the generations that will be. Ramban agrees. Sforno presses the consequence: you received this land on the understanding that later Jews would remain loyal; they inherit only on that basis. The berit is not a contract that dies with the signatories. Rabbi Jonathan Sacks returned to this throughout his writing: a contract is limited, bargained, and reversible; a covenant is an identity-forming bond that creates a "we" across time, including those who cannot yet speak. Nitzavim is that distinction in peshat. The unborn are not consulted. They are already named.

This is why the list runs from rasheichem to sho'ev meimecha. Rashi hears Canaanites who came to convert in Moshe's days, as the Gibeonites later came in Yehoshua's, and whom Moshe set to those labors. Ramban, reading the Tanchuma, will not say they deceived Moshe: they came to make peace; he would not cut a full covenant with them as equals, but he placed them at once in the camp's work. Either way the peshat remains: the ger inside the camp stands, and children and women stand. This is not a senate of adult males who will later inform the household. Hakhel will repeat the same census. The people of the berit is the people that can be gathered.

The first danger the Torah names after this assembly is not a public revolt. It is a private exemption.

"Lest there be among you a man or woman or family or tribe whose heart turns away this day from the L-rd our G-d to go to serve the gods of those nations; lest there be among you a root that produces poison and wormwood. And it shall be, when he hears the words of this oath, that he will bless himself in his heart, saying: I shall have peace, though I walk in the stubbornness of my heart — so that the watered is swept away with the dry" (29:17–18).

Rashi: perhaps there is among you one whose heart turns away this day from accepting the covenant; a root that increases bitterness in your midst. Vehitbarech bilvavo is a reflexive blessing. He imagines for himself a climate of peace. These curses will not reach me. Sherirut libo is what the heart looks at and elects. The crime is not only foreign worship. It is the inner speech that treats the berit as a public weather system from which a private climate can be carved.

Ramban deepens the psychology. Sherirut is desire that has become strong and established in the heart. A soul that was satiated takes a first small lust; having filled it, it becomes thirsty for what it had not wanted, and then thirsty for worse. The Sages' teaching that the more one satisfies the yetzer the hungrier it grows is, for Ramban, the peshat of the verse. The man who blesses himself does not remain a contained exception.

The private thought becomes a family, the family a tribe, and a later generation walks a burned land asking why.

Ohr HaChaim hears the terror of a holiness refused from inside the camp. The man is standing in the assembly; he hears the alah; he does not walk out; he edits the oath in his chest. Elul knows this figure. The King is in the field — and a person can come, hear Selichot, even answer Amen, and still bless himself that the accounting is for other people. The beinoni of Tanya fights. This man has declared a separate peace.

Then the Torah draws the line that governs all communal avodah:

"The hidden things belong to the L-rd our G-d, and the revealed things are for us and for our children forever, to do all the words of this Torah" (29:28).

Rashi, citing Sanhedrin 43b, answers the panic the previous verses might raise. If you say, What can we do — You threaten the many because of one person's thoughts, and no one knows his fellow's secrets? I do not punish you for the nistarot. Those are the L-rd's. The niglot are ours and our children's, to put away the evil from our midst; if we do not execute judgment upon them, the community is punished. The dots over lanu ulevaneinu teach that even for revealed sins the community was not punished until they crossed the Jordan and accepted mutual surety at Gerizim and Eival. Ramban records that reading and offers peshat of his own: nistarot as sins hidden even from those who commit them — shegiot mi yavin — for which we bear no guilt of transgression; niglot as the knowing sins, accepted as an eternal statute by those present and those not present. Ibn Ezra divides jurisdiction: secret idolatry is G-d's court; open breach is ours. Ohr HaChaim, linking the verse to the exile just described, can hear in the nistarot the hidden keitz, not given to us to calculate, while the niglot remain the work in every time, including the time when the end is still concealed.

The moral geometry must not be lost. Nitzavim will not permit a community to become a secret police of hearts, nor a bystander of public breach. Nistarot lashem Elokeinu limits inquisition. Vehaniglot lanu

ulevaneinu limits evasion. A person searches his own hidden things because they are not hidden from G-d. A people deals with what can be seen. The man who blesses himself is G-d's problem until his blessing becomes a public teaching; then he is ours. Areivut does not wait for perfect knowledge of anyone's interior.

Soloveitchik's berit goral is audible in the surety: I am bound to the one whose heart I cannot see because we were stood in the same camp. Sacks's covenant, as against contract, is audible in the unborn. Elazar's federal people is audible in ranks that stand without being identical. The pesukim were already thinking them. The revealed work of 21 Elul 5786 is not to speculate about other people's nistarot. It is to refuse the private blessing, to stand in the field with the whole list, and to keep the niglot from being abandoned.

III. Teshuvah as the Parsha's Engine

Nitzavim does not leave the assembly in the terror of the alah. Chapter 30 is the grammar of return.

"And it will be, when all these things come upon you — the blessing and the curse which I have set before you — that you will bring it back to your heart, among all the nations where the L-rd your G-d has banished you, and you will return to the L-rd your G-d and listen to His voice, you and your children, with all your heart and with all your soul" (30:1–2).

The sequence is exact. First the things come — blessing and curse, not a selected weather. Then vehashevota el levavecha: you will restore the matter to the heart. Then return, listening, children included, whole heart and whole soul. Teshuvah here is not a mood and not a brand. It is a cognitive act that becomes a covenantal act that becomes a transmitted act.

Then the verb Rashi will not flatten. Veshav Hashem Elokecha et shevutcha — Scripture wrote veshav, He will return, not only veheshiv, He will bring back. The Shechinah dwells with Israel in the misery of exile; when they are redeemed He writes redemption for Himself. The day of

gathering is so hard that it is as though He takes each Jew with His hands, one by one (30:3–4). The land is not a prize detached from the returner: He will bring you to the land your fathers possessed, and multiply you more than your fathers (30:5).

Then the inner surgery of Elul: "The L-rd your G-d will circumcise your heart and the heart of your offspring, to love the L-rd your G-d with all your heart and with all your soul, for the sake of your life" (30:6). Two movements sit in six verses and must not be collapsed. Verses 1–2 assign work to Israel: consider, return, listen, include the children. Verse 6 assigns work to G-d, so that love becomes possible lema'an chayecha. Ramban reads 30:6 with the Sages' "one who comes to purify himself is assisted from Above," and then more eschatologically: in the days of Mashiach the choice of the good will be natural; lust is the foreskin of the heart. Jeremiah's new covenant written on the heart and Ezekiel's new heart are, for Ramban, the same promise. Until that hour, free will remains the structure of the Torah-period.

Rambam legislates that structure. Hilchot Teshuvah 5: permission is given to every person — to turn to the good and be a tzaddik, or to turn to evil and be wicked. This is a great principle and a pillar of the Torah, and he cites our parsha (30:15) together with Re'eh's blessing and curse (11:26). The Creator does not compel. The heart is given. G-d desired that fire rise and that a human being have reshut. Hilchot Teshuvah 7 places teshuvah at the hinge of history: Israel will only be redeemed through teshuvah, and the Torah has already promised that they will return at the end of exile and immediately be redeemed — which is our chapter 30. The future tense of 30:1–2 is, as Ramban says of "this mitzvah" in 30:11, both command and pledge.

What is "this mitzvah" that is not too baffling and not far off, not in heaven and not across the sea, but very near, in your mouth and in your heart, to do it (30:11–14)? Many mefarshim take it of the whole Torah. Rashi: it is not concealed; were it in heaven you would still have to go up after it; it was given in writing and orally. Ramban says the correct reading is teshuvah itself: when the Torah means the entire Torah it says

kol hamitzvah; hamitzvah hazot points back to vehashevota and veshavta. Mouth is confession; heart is return; la'asoto is acceptance of Torah across generations. Sforno and Kli Yakar walk the same road. Kli Yakar hears the sinner's despair — it is too far, I have ruined too much — and the Torah's refusal of that despair. Nearness is not ease. Nearness is that no distance and no private mythology of impossibility gets to cancel the work.

This is why teshuvah is the engine of the combined parsha and not a self-help slogan. Devarim 30 tells a people that exile is not the last word of the berit, that return is commanded before it is felt, that G-d returns with the returners, and that until the heart's foreskin is cut from Above the thing is near enough to do. The Alter Rebbe's mashal of Elul, in Likkutei Torah on Re'eh, belongs here without being stretched. Before the King returns to the palace for the Days of Awe He goes out to the field; anyone who wishes may approach, and He receives all with a cheerful countenance. Accessibility does not abolish kingship. It maximizes the hour in which a free agent who would not have passed the guards of the court can begin teshuvah. The Rebbe stressed that the Thirteen Attributes in Elul do not compel service; they enable it. Itaruta diletata is 30:1–2; Itaruta dile'eila is 30:6. Elul is the month in which the two may meet in ordinary places before the palace protocol of Rosh Hashanah.

On this 21 Elul in Jerusalem that meeting is not abstract. Selichot have already been said in the Land; the shofar has been sounding; Rosh Hashanah 5787 is eight days away; the King is still in the field. The engine of the parsha is not self-improvement as a slogan. It is: bring blessing and curse back to the heart; return with the children; trust that He returns with you; do the near thing in mouth and heart; leave the final circumcision of the heart to Him.

IV. Choose Life as the Vocation of the Klal

"See — I have set before you today life and good, death and evil… I call heaven and earth to witness against you today: life and death I have set before you, the blessing and the curse. Choose life, so that you may live,

you and your seed, to love the L-rd your G-d, to listen to His voice, and to cleave to Him, for He is your life and the length of your days" (30:15–20).

This is one movement of the whole parsha, not a separate daily-portion architecture. Rashi binds the pairs: life depends on good, death on evil. Heaven and earth are witnesses because they exist without reward and without punishment and never deviate from their work; human beings, who stand to gain and to lose, have still less excuse. "Choose life" is not a shrug of neutrality. It is a father walking his son onto the good portion of the estate and saying, Take this. Tehillim 16:5 is the inner voice of that guidance: You rest Your hand on the good lot.

Ramban hears Moshe returning to exhort after blessing, curse, and teshuvah have already been set down. Two courses lie in Israel's hand. It is in their power to walk in whichever they desire. There is no power below or above that will withhold them or stop them. Heaven and earth are signed at the end of the deed, like witnesses who close a document after all its clauses. The counsel "choose life" is not coercion. It is the last human word a shepherd is allowed to speak once freedom has been established as real.

Rambam takes 30:15 as a pillar of the entire Torah: without this seeing, teshuvah itself would be incoherent. The vocation is not exhausted by the individual's bechirah. The purpose clause is collective: so that you may live, you and your seed. Hu chayecha — He is your life — is said to a people about to cross the Jordan as a people. Choose life is the yeud of a klal already stood in the goral. Fate has assembled them; destiny is the choosing. Sacks's covenant, as against contract, chooses a life together, including those not yet born. Elazar's covenantal people chooses in ranks, not by a single will and not by a sum of private preferences that never have to stand in one place.

The seeing here is the vocation of the whole combined parsha, not a reconstruction of another day's learning: a standing people, capable of private heresy and of public return, is told that life is choosable and that the choice is for children. Hishtadlut is real. Emunah is real. Neither

cancels the other. Heaven and earth will still be there if we refuse. The King in the field will not force the hand that blesses itself. Choose life is the avodah of 23 Elul because Rosh Hashanah will ask, in public, whether this people still wishes to be a people of the Name.

V. Vayeilech: The Leader Walks, the People Is Charged, the Torah Is Left as Witness

"Moshe went and spoke these things to all Israel" (31:1). He is one hundred and twenty years old; he can no longer go out and come in. This is not, Rashi insists, a confession of exhausted strength; Devarim 34 will still say that his moisture did not depart. Lo uchal od latzet velavo is reshut: authority has already been transferred toward Yehoshua. A man can be at the height of his powers and still be commanded to make room. Limited tenure under a higher command is not failure. It is avodah.

Hashem will cross before the people. Yehoshua will cross before them. Then the double charge that will echo into Yehoshua's own book: Chizku ve'imtzu — be strong and courageous; Hashem your G-d goes with you; He will not slacken His hold and He will not abandon you (31:3–6). Moshe says the same words to Yehoshua in the sight of all Israel (31:7–8). Succession is a public charge under a G-d who remains the One who actually crosses first. Rambam's Hilchot Melachim will later bind a king to write a Sefer Torah and read it all his days so that his heart not be lifted above his brothers. The leader is replaceable. The berit is not.

Moshe writes this Torah and gives it to the Kohanim, sons of Levi, who carry the Ark, and to all the elders of Israel (31:9). Then the mitzvah that is the public square of the covenant itself:

"At the end of seven years, at the time of the shemittah year, on the festival of Sukkot, when all Israel comes to appear before the L-rd your G-d in the place He will choose, you shall read this Torah opposite all Israel in their ears. Gather the people — the men and the women and the children, and your ger who is in your gates — so that they will hear and so that they will learn, and they will fear the L-rd your G-d, and they will take care to do all the words of this Torah. And their children who did not

know will hear and will learn to fear… all the days you live on the soil" (31:10–13).

Hakhel is not a pageant. Rambam, Hilchot Chagigah 3, treats it as a reenactment of Sinai: gathered to hear, to learn, to fear, to do. The king reads, which dignifies the event; if there is no king, the mitzvah is not void. Ramban on 31:12–13, with Maharal in the Gur Aryeh, hears why even small children are brought: those who can study are moved to study more; those who can listen are moved to live; the youngest absorb, by seeing the entire people gather for words, the importance of Torah; and the parents remember chinuch. Ibn Ezra and Ramban dispute seventh year or eighth; halachah places it at the Sukkot that closes the shemittah. After a year in which the land itself was released from private grasp, the people re-accept Torah in public.

Elazar's covenantal federalism fits hakhel without strain. A federal people is reconstituted by periodic assembly under the document that none of the partners may unilaterally alter. Men, women, children, and the ger in the gates are the original census of the covenant-people, matching Nitzavim's opening list. Hakhel is Nitzavim made calendrical: every seven years, in the place G-d chooses, a leader reads what he did not write to a people that includes those who "did not know." Transmission is the public avodah of the klal.

Then the Torah does a harder thing. Hashem tells Moshe his days have drawn near. Call Yehoshua; present yourselves in the Tent. And G-d says: you are about to lie with your fathers, and this people will rise and go astray after the foreign gods of the land; they will abandon Me and break My covenant. Anger will flare; I will hide My face; they will say, Is it not because my G-d is not in my midst that these evils have found me? And I will surely hide My face on that day (31:16–18).

The prediction is not despair, because it is immediately turned into witness. "Write for yourselves this song and teach it to the children of Israel; place it in their mouths, so that this song shall be a witness for Me" (31:19). When they eat and grow fat and turn, the song will answer, for it

will not be forgotten from the mouth of their seed. Moshe writes the song that day. He writes the words of the Torah to their very end. He charges the Levites to place the Sefer beside the Ark as a witness. I know your rebelliousness now; how much more after my death. Gather the elders; I will call heaven and earth to witness (31:19–29). Then he speaks the song to the end, in the ears of the whole congregation.

The genius of Vayeilech is that it refuses two lies. One is that a great leader makes a people immune: Moshe is a hundred and twenty, his moisture has not departed, and G-d still says they will stray. The other is that predicted straying is the last word. The song will not be forgotten from the mouth of the seed. The Sefer sits beside the Ark. Heaven and earth remain signed. Teshuvah remains near. Hakhel remains on the calendar. The hiding of the Face is real — haster astir — and it is not abandonment of the berit. A witness is not a eulogy. A witness is what makes return possible, because return requires that the terms still be known.

Kli Yakar and Ohr HaChaim hear in the song a mercy inside the accusation: Israel will not be able to say they were not told. Sforno hears in the writing to the very end that the public document is complete. Read with Nitzavim they say one thing. The people stood. The leader walks. The Torah remains. The children who did not know will hear. The seed will still have the song in its mouth. That is not optimism. It is emunah with hishtadlut: write, teach, gather, charge, and then lie down with the fathers, leaving the klal under a G-d who goes with them.

VI. The Haftarah of Consolation as the Week's Prophetic Counter-Voice

Verified against the Chabad calendar for 5 September 2026 / 23 Elul 5786, and against Hebcal's listing for Nitzavim–Vayeilech 5786, the haftarah of this Shabbat is Yeshayahu 61:10–63:9, Sos asis, the seventh and last of the sheva denechamta, the seven haftarot of consolation that run from the Shabbat after Tisha B'Av until the Shabbat before Rosh Hashanah. Tosafot on Megillah 31b already noted the practice: consolations increase, and

Sos asis is always read with Atem nitzavim, the Shabbat before Rosh Hashanah, because it is the ultimate of consolations.

The prophet begins where Nitzavim's frightened faces needed to begin: joy. "I will greatly rejoice in the L-rd; my soul shall exult in my G-d, for He has clothed me with garments of salvation… as a bridegroom ministers with splendor, and as a bride adorns herself with her jewels" (61:10). The berit that in Moav is oath and imprecation is, in the last consolation, wedding clothes. Rashi had said that the day darkens and shines again. Yeshayahu says the shining is nuptial (61:11).

Then the refusal of passivity that is Elul's public voice: "For the sake of Zion I will not be silent, and for the sake of Jerusalem I will not be still, until her righteousness go forth like brightness" (62:1). Watchmen on the walls shall never be silent; those who remind the L-rd are not to give Him rest until He establish Jerusalem (62:6–7). The Land will no longer be called Forsaken; she will be Cheftzi-bah and Beulah — "as a bridegroom rejoices over a bride, so will your G-d rejoice over you" (62:4–5). They shall be called the Holy People, the Redeemed of the L-rd; and you, Sought Out, a city not forsaken (62:12).

The haftarah then turns through Edom and Bozrah, garments stained as from a winepress, the day of vengeance and the year of redemption, a redemption in which G-d looked and there was no helper, so His own arm saved Him (63:1–6). It is not a gentle appendix. Consolation in Yeshayahu is not the erasure of judgment. It is judgment that has a Bride at the end of it. Then the lines that answer Vayeilech's hiding of the Face from the other side:

"In all their affliction He was afflicted, and the angel of His presence saved them; in His love and in His pity He redeemed them; He bore them and carried them all the days of old" (63:9).

Rashi on 30:3 had already said that the Shechinah dwells with Israel in exile and returns with them. The haftarah is that teaching in the prophet's mouth. Haster astir is true; He is afflicted in their affliction is also true. The King in the field is not a different G-d from the G-d who

hides His face. He is nearer in Elul so that the hiding of Tishrei not be met by a people that never came. The seventh consolation is read with Nitzavim because a people told it will stray, and that must nevertheless choose life, is not permitted to hear only the prediction.

On 23 Elul 5786 this is the week's counter-voice. The Torah portion gathers, warns, commands return and choice, transfers leadership, and predicts breach. The navi answers with a wedding, a refusal to be still for Zion, and a G-d who carries. The prophetic voice does not cancel Moshe's last charges. It keeps them from being heard as a closed doom.

May we merit, in these last days of Elul 5786, to stand as one people before the Name, to refuse the private blessing of a separate peace, to return with our children while the King is still in the field, and to walk into the year 5787 with Torah in the mouth and the song not forgotten from the seed.

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The essay's own source notes

Parsha and calendar (verified 3 September 2026)

- Combined reading Nitzavim–Vayeilech: Devarim 29:9–31:30. Chabad calendar for Shabbat 5 September 2026 / 23 Elul 5786: chabad.org/calendar. Hebcal: Nitzavim-Vayeilech 5786.
- Sefaria, Devarim 29–31: sefaria.org/Deuteronomy.29.9 through Deuteronomy.31.30.

- Haftarah, seventh of consolation: Yeshayahu 61:10–63:9. Confirmed on the same Chabad day-page and Hebcal listing. Text: sefaria.org/Isaiah.61.10. Chabad nutshell: Nitzavim Haftorah.

Peshat and mefarshim

- Rashi on Devarim 29:9–31:30 (assembly on the day of death; calming after the tochacha; those not here as future generations; the reflexive private blessing; nistarot / niglot and mutual surety; veshav as the Shechinah returning with the exiles; Torah not in heaven; choose life as a father seating a son on the good portion; lo uchal od as transferred reshut). Sefaria, Rashi on Deuteronomy 29.
- Ramban on 29:9–30:20 (readiness for covenant; ranks; future generations; psychology of sherirut and the watered/thirsty; peshat of nistarot as unwitting sins; chapter 30 as future; teshuvah as "this mitzvah"; circumcision of the heart in the days of Mashiach; free will unobstructed by any power below or above). Sefaria, Ramban on Deuteronomy 29.
- Ibn Ezra on rasheichem shivteichem; his dispute with Ramban on the year of hakhel.
- Sforno on 29:14 (land held on condition of later loyalty); on the completeness of the written Torah at transmission.
- Ohr HaChaim and Kli Yakar on the private root, on nistarot as (among other readings) the hidden keitz, and on 30:11–14 as the nearness of teshuvah against the sinner's despair.
- Midrash Tanchuma, Nitzavim; Sifrei Devarim; Sanhedrin 43b; Megillah 29a; Eruvin 55a.

Halachah and Chassidus

- Rambam, Mishneh Torah, Hilchot Teshuvah 5 (free will as pillar, citing Devarim 30:15) and 7 (redemption only through teshuvah; the Torah's promise in this chapter). Chabad, Teshuvah ch. 5 · Sefaria, Hilchot Teshuvah.

- Rambam, Hilchot Melachim (the king's Torah; limited heart); Hilchot Chagigah 3 (hakhel as Sinai reenacted).
- Alter Rebbe, Likkutei Torah, Nitzavim (44a ff.) and Re'eh (the King in the field).
- Lubavitcher Rebbe, Likkutei Sichos vol. 24, pp. 188–196 (standing "before Him as a nation"; hayom as Rosh Hashanah; immutable berit); vol. 2, pp. 398–400 (unity of heads and woodchoppers as the beyond-logic avodah that draws a beyond-logic covenant). English presentations: Sichos in English, The Chassidic Dimension, Nitzavim.

Thinkers drawn on as they actually speak

- Rabbi Joseph B. Soloveitchik, Kol Dodi Dofek — berit goral (covenant of fate) and berit yeud (covenant of destiny), paraphrased, not quoted from a page.
- Rabbi Jonathan Sacks — covenant as identity-forming bond across generations, as against a reversible contract; paraphrased from the line of Covenant and Conversation and related essays.
- Daniel J. Elazar, Covenant and Polity in Biblical Israel and the Covenant Tradition in Politics — biblical berit as federal, reconstitutable assembly under higher law; applied here to Nitzavim's ranks and to hakhel, not as a theory of non-domination.

SOURCE READING 7.1

Good to Heaven and Good to People

התוועדות ליל כ"ט אלול ה'תשל"ז, חלק א

Hisvaaduyos, night of 29 Elul 5737, Erev Rosh Hashanah 5738, part 1 (unedited transcript)

Key idea

At the farbrengen on the night of 29 Elul 5737, after the maamar "זה היום תחלת מעשיך," the Rebbe drew a lesson from that year's calendar. Rosh Hashanah fell on a Tuesday, and so, by the sign of the Baal HaTurim

("פתבג המלך"), Nitzavim and Vayeilech were read separately. Tuesday is the day on which "it was good" was said twice, which the Gemara reads as "good to Heaven and good to people": in every act and every mitzvah, both together, as one thing.

Rosh Hashanah is the "king" of the year, like a head that includes and directs every limb, and a king's rule is unlike a teacher's or a father's: "a king who forgoes his honor, his honor is not forgone." Since everything follows the conclusion, on the single day of Erev Rosh Hashanah one can complete the whole year through good resolutions; and Hashem gives in return, measure for measure and many times more, in spiritual and material matters, until the two become one. The practical start: the ten mivtzoim, beginning with love of every Jew.

Summary prepared for this booklet from the source file.

In the source's own words

English renderings are working translations prepared for this booklet.

> וזוהי ההוראה כשר"ה חל ונקבע ביום השלישי – שמתחילה שנה באופן ש"טוב לשמים וטוב לבריות" הם אצלו בתור יום אחד, ענין אחד
>
> *This is the lesson when Rosh Hashanah falls on the third day of the week: one begins the year so that "good to Heaven and good to people" are, for him, one day, one matter.*
>
> p. 4 (PDF p. 4)

> משא"כ בנוגע למלך – הרי "מלך שמחל על כבודו אין כבודו מחול"
>
> *But with a king, "a king who forgoes his honor, his honor is not forgone."*
>
> p. 5 (PDF p. 5)

> ביום אחד ויחידי של ערב ר"ה – משלימים בנ"י את כל הענינים
>
> *On one single day, Erev Rosh Hashanah, the Jewish people complete everything.*
>
> p. 6 (PDF p. 6)

For discussion

1. What changes when "good to Heaven" and "good to people" are one act rather than two?

2. Why is a king's guidance different from a teacher's or a parent's? What does that say about crowning Hashem on Rosh Hashanah?
3. "Everything follows the conclusion." What would it mean to close this week well?

Cite inline: (the Lubavitcher Rebbe, *Hisvaaduyos* 29 Elul 5737, part 1, Otzar HaChassidim offprint)

Full citation: The Lubavitcher Rebbe, Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson, *Hisvaaduyos*, sicha of Sunday of Parshat Vayeilech, night of 29 Elul 5737, Erev Rosh Hashanah 5738, part 1, bilti mugah (unedited transcript), printed from p. 3, issued for Rosh Hashanah 5787 (foreword dated the third day of Selichot 5786), Sifrei Otzar HaChassidim, Lubavitch; prepared for print by Vaad Hanochos B'Lahak; Brooklyn, NY: Lahak Hanochos Inc., 2026 (5787) (copyright page); www.lahak.org [link to confirm]; Drive, Laptop Downloads 2026-11-06 folder (ID 1fNxl4_0JJ79V4poWB0eCONu1cg0X3sRW), inside the part01–part04 ZIP archives.

• Unedited transcript (bilti mugah): cite it as such.

SOURCE READING 7.2

When Rosh Hashanah Falls on Shabbos

מאמרי ד"ה יו"ט של ראש השנה שחל להיות בשבת

Two maamarim, Erev Rosh Hashanah 5736 and 5737 (unedited transcripts)

Key idea

Two maamarim with the same opening, said at the farbrengens of 29 Elul 5735 and 29 Elul 5736, in years when Rosh Hashanah fell on Shabbos. The first starts from Rambam (Hilchot Teshuvah 3:4): the shofar hints "Awake, sleepers, from your sleep," the general call to teshuvah, and also the three themes of the day, Malchiyos, Zichronos and Shofros. Crowning the King on Rosh Hashanah must be roused from the innermost delight above; shofar is related to "shefer," beauty and delight; and so the service of the day is bound up with delight, even in weeping, like Rabbi Akiva's tears of delight over Shir HaShirim.

Because Shabbos itself draws down what the shofar accomplishes, the shofar is not sounded outside the Mikdash when Rosh Hashanah falls on Shabbos, yet the shofar verses are still said. In the Mikdash, and in the "Mikdash" within every Jew, the inner heart, they did sound it, drawing a higher level connected with the great shofar of the future. The second maamar adds that the main work of the shofar, teshuvah, is done by Shabbos itself, "שבת אותיות תשב."

Summary prepared for this booklet from the source file.

In the source's own words

English renderings are working translations prepared for this booklet.

> אע"פ שתק"ש בר"ה גזירת הכתוב, רמז יש בו, כלומר, עורו ישנים משנתכם וכו'
>
> *"Although the sounding of the shofar on Rosh Hashanah is a decree of Scripture, it carries a hint, that is: Awake, sleepers, from your sleep ..." (Rambam).*
>
> p. ה (PDF p. 5)

> שאמרו על ר' עקיבא שכשאמר (ולמד) שיר השירים זלגו עיניו דמעות, שזה מורה על פנימיות ושלימות ענין התענוג
>
> *As they said of Rabbi Akiva that when he said (and learned) Shir HaShirim his eyes streamed with tears, which shows the innermost and complete level of delight.*
>
> p. ו (PDF p. 6)

> וטעם הדבר, לפי שגם שבת שייך לענין התשובה, שלכן שבת אותיות תשב
>
> *The reason is that Shabbos too is connected with teshuvah; this is why the letters of Shabbos (שבת) are the letters of "return" (תשב).*
>
> p. יג (PDF p. 13)

For discussion

1. How can a day of judgment be bound up with delight?
2. If Shabbos already does what the shofar does, why are the shofar verses still said?
3. What is the "Mikdash within every Jew," and what would it mean for the shofar to sound there?

Cite inline: (the Lubavitcher Rebbe, maamarim *Yom Tov shel Rosh Hashanah* 5736 and 5737, Otzar HaChassidim offprint)

Full citation: The Lubavitcher Rebbe, Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson, two maamarim *Yom Tov shel Rosh Hashanah shechal lihyos b'Shabbos* (ד"ה יו"ט של ראש השנה שחל להיות בשבת), said at the farbrengens of Erev Rosh Hashanah 5736 (29 Elul 5735) and Erev Rosh Hashanah 5737 (29 Elul 5736), hanacha bilti mugah (unedited transcripts), printed pp. ד–יט, offprint from Sefer HaMaamarim Moadim, Rosh Hashanah, issued for Rosh Hashanah 5787 (foreword dated Motzaei Shabbat 23 Elul 5786), Sifrei Otzar HaChassidim, Lubavitch; prepared for print by Vaad Hanochos B'Lahak; Brooklyn, NY: Lahak Hanochos Inc., 2026 (5787) (copyright page); www.lahak.org [link to confirm]; Drive, Laptop Downloads 2026-11-06 folder (ID 1fNxl4_0JJ79V4poWB0eCONu1cg0X3sRW), inside the part01–part04 ZIP archives.

• Unedited transcripts (bilti mugah): cite them as such.

FURTHER LEARNING

Commentary, haftarah and Tehillim

The essay reads Nitzavim and Vayeilech, and the maamarim speak of Erev Rosh Hashanah and the shofar. These texts add Rashi on the standing people, the psalm of Elul and the Talmud on the shofar.

Hebrew quoted from the texts on Sefaria, checked 10 November 2026. English renderings are working translations prepared for this booklet.

Standing firm between leaders

דבר אחר — אתם נצבים, לפי שהיו ישראל יוצאין מפרנס לפרנס — ממשה ליהושע — לפיכך עשה אותם מצבה כדי לזרזם

Another explanation of "You are standing": because Israel were passing from one leader to another, from Moshe to Yehoshua, he therefore made them stand together as a pillar, to strengthen them.

Rashi on Devarim 29:12 · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Deuteronomy.29.12

Rashi's second reading speaks directly to this chapter's title. On the day leadership passes from Moshe to Yehoshua, the people are made to stand together, firm as a pillar. First the people stands, then the leader walks.

The covenant does not rest on any one leader, however great, but on a people that stands together before Hashem.

Tehillim: the shofar at the hidden moon

> תקעו בחדש שופר בכסה ליום חגנו כי חק לישראל הוא משפט לאלקי יעקב
>
> *Sound the shofar at the new moon, at the hidden time, for our festival day; for it is a statute for Israel, a judgment of the G-d of Yaakov.*
>
> Tehillim 81:4–5 · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.81.4-5

The Talmud (Rosh Hashanah 8b; Beitzah 16a) asks which festival falls when the moon is hidden, and answers: Rosh Hashanah, the only festival on the first of the month. In many communities this verse is said on the night of Rosh Hashanah. The maamarim of this chapter explain why, when Rosh Hashanah falls on Shabbos, the shofar is not sounded and Shabbos itself does its work. Even hidden, the day does its work.

Kingship, remembrance and the shofar

> ואמרו לפני בראש השנה מלכיות זכרונות ושופרות. מלכיות — כדי שתמליכוני עליכם, זכרונות — כדי שיעלה זכרוניכם לפני לטובה, ובמה — בשופר
>
> *And say before Me on Rosh Hashanah Malchiyos, Zichronos and Shofros: Malchiyos, so that you crown Me king over you; Zichronos, so that your remembrance rises before Me for good; and with what? With the shofar.*
>
> Talmud Bavli, Rosh Hashanah 16a · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Rosh_Hashanah.16a

This is the source of the three central blessings of the Musaf of Rosh Hashanah, and the background of the farbrengen of 29 Elul 5737, where Rosh Hashanah is the “king” of the year. The Talmud joins the three: we crown Him, we are remembered for good, and both happen through the shofar, a sound without words.

Questions for the chapter

1. Why must the covenant include “those who are not here with us today”?
2. What is the difference between the hidden things that belong to Hashem and the revealed things that are ours?

3. How does teshuvah become the engine of the whole parsha?
4. On Erev Rosh Hashanah, how can “good to Heaven” and “good to people” become one act?
5. If Shabbos already does what the shofar does, what does that teach about rest and return?
6. Rashi says the people stood together “to strengthen them” as leadership passed. What makes a community strong in a time of change?
7. If you could ask Hashem for “one thing” this year, what would it be?
8. Why would the crowning of the King need the wordless sound of the shofar?

CHAPTER 8

Many Waters, and the Simple Jew's Sukkah

From Tishrei into the weekday year

When Tishrei ends, "Yaakov goes on his way" into the ordinary year. The maamar "Mayim Rabim," said on Motzaei Shabbos Noach 5738, teaches that the many waters of livelihood cannot quench the hidden love in every Jewish soul, and that through them the soul rises higher than before. It is read here from the explained edition of Rabbi Menachem Mendel Ashkenazi.

The chapter closes with a talk of the first night of Sukkos 5706 on the customs of Lubavitch: the Baal Shem Tov's joy with simple Jews, who were "the decoration of his sukkah," and a son's memory of his father's Erev Sukkos in 5658. The pages do not name the speaker, so the attribution is left [to confirm].

Introduction prepared for this booklet.

SOURCE READING 8.1

Many Waters Cannot Quench the Love

מאמר ד"ה מים רבים, ה'תשל"ח

Maamar "Mayim Rabim" 5738, in Biurim B'Maamarei Rabbeinu (explained edition)

Key idea

"Many waters cannot quench the love, nor can rivers drown it" (Shir HaShirim 8:7). The "many waters" are the worries of earning a living and the thoughts of worldly affairs; the "rivers" are their unbroken stream of

new plans. Even so, they cannot quench the hidden love that is in every Jewish soul.

The Rebbe weighs the phrase "worries of livelihood." The verse says "the toil of your hands": the hands should toil, not the mind and the heart. One whose mind and heart are troubled by livelihood is at a low level, and still the love is not quenched. The waters are rooted in Tohu, which preceded the ordered world; the soul is rooted higher still, in the Essence of the Infinite Light. More than that, through these very worries the soul rises to the level of a baal teshuvah, the purpose of its descent. Knowing that the descent is for the sake of the ascent makes the work of the weekday year ("ויעקב הלך לדרכו," after Tishrei) a work of joy, and joy breaks through every limit.

Summary prepared for this booklet from the source file.

In the source's own words

English renderings are working translations prepared for this booklet.

> מים רבים לא יוכלו לכבות את האהבה ונהרות לא ישטפוה גו', ואיתא בדרושי רבותינו נשיאינו, שמים רבים הם כל טרדות הפרנסה והמחשבות שבעניני עולם הזה
>
> *"Many waters cannot quench the love, nor can rivers drown it." The discourses of our Rebbeim explain that the many waters are all the worries of livelihood and the thoughts about the affairs of this world.*
>
> p. ה (PDF p. 5)

> יגיע כפיך דוקא אבל לא יגיעת המוח והלב
>
> *"The toil of your hands" specifically, but not the toil of the mind and the heart.*
>
> p. ה (PDF p. 5)

> על-ידי ה'מים רבים' מגיעה הנשמה למדריגה נעלית יותר – שבאה למעלת התשובה, אשר בשביל זה ירדה למטה
>
> *Through the "many waters" the soul reaches a higher level: it comes to the quality of teshuvah, for the sake of which it came down below. (explainers' summary)*
>
> p. י (PDF p. 10); a summary line written by the explainers for §ד (repeated in their general summary, p. טו)

For discussion

1. Where do the “many waters” of livelihood reach your mind and heart, and not only your hands?
2. How can worries that pull a person down become the means of rising higher than before?
3. Why does the knowledge that “descent is for ascent” lead specifically to joy?

Cite inline: (the Lubavitcher Rebbe, maamar *Mayim Rabim* 5738, explained edition)

Full citation: The Lubavitcher Rebbe, Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson, maamar *Mayim Rabim* 5738 (said Motzaei Shabbat Parshat Noach 5738, issued edited on 7 MarCheshvan 5738, per the booklet), in *Biurim B’Maamarei Rabbeinu: Maamar D"H Mayim Rabim 5738*, explanations gathered and written by Rabbi Menachem Mendel Ashkenazi, drawing on explanations given by Rabbi Yoel Kahan, summaries by Rabbi Levi Yitzchak Epstein, printed by special permission of Kehot (per the foreword), foreword dated Erev Shabbat Parshat Noach 5786, correspondence P.O. Box 485, Kfar Chabad, 16 pp.; Drive, Laptop Downloads 2026-11-06 folder (ID 1fNxl4_0JJ79V4poWB0eCONu1cg0X3sRW), inside the part01–part04 ZIP archives.

• Publisher’s name is not printed beyond the compiler and the Kfar Chabad address [to confirm].

• That the 8-page booklet version in the batch has the same content [to confirm].

SOURCE READING 8.2

The Simple Jew as the Beauty of the Sukkah

ליל א' דחג הסוכות תש"ו

Sicha of the first night of Sukkos 5706 (speaker not named on the pages)

Key idea

The customs of Lubavitch rest on the conduct of the Alter Rebbe, who gave himself with self-sacrifice to the customs of the Baal Shem Tov. One of those customs was to serve with joy on Sukkos together with the

simplest Jews. The Alter Rebbe quoted the Baal Shem Tov that the mitzvah of a simple Jew, done out of faith in the Essence, is a vessel for the Essence; and the Baal Shem Tov said that the decorations of his sukkah were the simple Jews who accept the yoke.

The speaker then recalls his father's Erev Sukkos in 5658: rising at three for the mikveh, learning together at six, examining the esrogim, binding the lulav and carrying it in with a joyful niggun, and entering the sukkah with "the joy of Hashem is his strength." He goes on to describe the small towns of Russia, where even market Jews kept fixed times for Torah and supported scholars, and contrasts the pull of money in America, crediting Tomchei Temimim's five years there with strengthening "form over matter."

Summary prepared for this booklet from the source file.

In the source's own words

English renderings are working translations prepared for this booklet.

> ידוע המאמר־קודש שאדמו"ר הזקן היה אומר בשם הבעש"ט, שקיום המצוות של היהודי הפשוט — המקיימם מתוך אמונתו בעצמות — הוא כלי לעצמות, וגורם נחת רוח לעצמות
>
> *It is known, the holy saying that the Alter Rebbe would repeat in the name of the Baal Shem Tov: the mitzvah-keeping of the simple Jew, who keeps the mitzvos out of his faith in the Essence, is a vessel for the Essence and brings it gratification.*
>
> p. 1 of 9 (pages unnumbered)

> הבעש"ט היה אומר שהנוי סוכה שלו הם היהודים הפשוטים בעלי הקבלת־עול, הגורמים למעלה שמחה בשמחת־המצוה שלהם הבאה מתוך אמונה פשוטה
>
> *The Baal Shem Tov used to say that the decorations of his sukkah were the simple Jews who accept the yoke, who bring joy above through their joy in the mitzvah, which comes from simple faith.*
>
> p. 1 of 9 (pages unnumbered)

> העיירות הקטנות שברוסיה היו בימות החול מקומות של תורה ועבודה
>
> *The small towns of Russia were, on weekdays, places of Torah and service.*
>
> p. 3 of 9 (pages unnumbered)

For discussion

1. Why would the Baal Shem Tov call simple Jews, and not scholars, the beauty of his sukkah?
2. What does careful preparation of a mitzvah, like binding the lulav, add to the mitzvah itself?
3. What would “form over matter” look like in a home today?

Cite inline: (Sicha of Leil Alef d'Chag HaSukkos 5706, §א)

Full citation: Speaker [to confirm], *Leil Alef d'Chag HaSukkos 5706* (ליל א' דחג הסוכות תש"ו), sicha on the customs of Lubavitch and joy on Sukkos, nine pages, Word document prepared by the user “dovi” on 18 August 2026, publisher [to confirm]; Drive, Laptop Downloads 2026-11-06 folder (ID 1fNxl4_0JJ79V4poWB0eCONu1cg0X3sRW), inside the part01–part04 ZIP archives. [single source]

• The pages do not name the speaker. He speaks of his father as “הוד כ"ק אאמו"ר הרה"ק,” recalls Sukkos 5658 and mentions Tomchei Temimim’s five years in America. These details fit the Previous Rebbe, Rabbi Yosef Yitzchak Schneersohn, but do not attribute it until confirmed [to confirm].

• Only one copy of this item is in the batch [single source].

FURTHER LEARNING

Commentary, haftarah and Tehillim

The last chapter moves from the many waters to the sukkah. Rashi, the Talmud, the Torah’s mitzvah of the sukkah, Tehillim and the haftarah of the first day of Sukkos complete the circle of the year.

Hebrew quoted from the texts on Sefaria, checked 10 November 2026. English renderings are working translations prepared for this booklet.

Rashi on the many waters

מים רבים. האמות: ונהרות. שריהם ומלכיהם: לא ישטפוה. על ידי חזק ואימה, ואף על ידי פתוי והסתה

“Many waters”: the nations. “And rivers”: their princes and their kings. “Cannot drown it”: neither by force and terror, nor by enticement and persuasion.

Rashi on Shir HaShirim 8:7 · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Song_of_Songs.8.7

Rashi reads the "many waters" as the nations, who try to quench Israel's love by terror and by temptation. The maamar "Mayim Rabim" reads them as the worries of livelihood. One is an outer exile and the other an inner one, and neither can put out the love. The maamar adds that the soul, passing through the waters, rises higher than before.

Pouring water on Sukkos

ומפני מה אמרה תורה נסכו מים בחג — אמר הקדוש ברוך הוא: נסכו לפני מים בחג, כדי שיתברכו לכם גשמי שנה

And why did the Torah say, pour out water on the festival? The Holy One, blessed be He, said: Pour out water before Me on the festival, so that the rains of the year may be blessed for you.

Talmud Bavli, Rosh Hashanah 16a · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Rosh_Hashanah.16a

On Sukkos water was poured on the altar, the nisuch hamayim, so that the year's rains would be blessed. Here the waters bless. The same waters that in the maamar stand for the cares of livelihood are, on Sukkos, poured out before Hashem, so that the whole year's livelihood is blessed.

Clouds of glory, or real huts

כי בסוכות הושבתי את בני ישראל", ענני כבוד היו, דברי רבי אליעזר. רבי עקיבא אומר: סוכות ממש עשו להם

"For I made the children of Israel dwell in sukkos" (Vayikra 23:43): they were clouds of glory; these are the words of Rabbi Eliezer. Rabbi Akiva says: they made themselves real booths.

Talmud Bavli, Sukkah 11b · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Sukkah.11b

Rashi on the verse follows Rabbi Eliezer: "clouds of glory." Rabbi Akiva holds that they were real huts. Both readings are Torah, and both live in the sukkah we build. The talk of 5706 says that the simple Jews were the decoration of the Baal Shem Tov's sukkah. Perhaps that joins the two opinions: a hut of plain boards becomes a cloud of glory when simple faith sits inside it.

Tehillim: hidden in His sukkah

כי יצפנני בסכה ביום רעה יסתרני בסתר אהלו בצור ירוממני

For He will hide me in His sukkah on the day of evil; He will conceal me in the shelter of His tent; He will lift me up on a rock.

Tehillim 27:5 · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.27.5

Tehillim 27, "L'Dovid Hashem ori," is said through Elul and the festival season, and on Sukkos Dovid's request is fulfilled: to be hidden "in His sukkah." The sukkah is a shelter that is not a wall, open to the sky and yet a hiding place. It is the first chapter's "Jerusalem will dwell unwalled," lived for seven days each year.

The haftarah of Sukkos: One and His Name One

והיה ה' למלך על כל הארץ ביום ההוא יהיה ה' אחד ושמו אחד

And Hashem will be King over all the earth; on that day Hashem will be One and His Name One.

Zechariah 14:9, from the haftarah of the first day of Sukkos · Sefaria: https://www.sefaria.org/Zechariah.14.9

The haftarah of the first day of Sukkos, Zechariah 14, foresees all the nations going up to Jerusalem to keep Sukkos (14:16), and its best-known verse closes the Aleinu prayer every day. The booklet began with the world created in wisdom and given to its Owner. It ends with that Owner recognized by all the earth. From Bereishis to Sukkos, the circle closes.

Questions for the chapter

1. Where do the worries of livelihood reach your mind and heart, and not only your hands?
2. How can knowing that "descent is for ascent" bring joy into ordinary work?
3. Why would simple faith be the beauty of a sukkah?
4. What one practice of Tishrei will you carry into the weekday year?
5. Rashi reads the "many waters" as outer pressures and the maamar as inner worries. Which kind is harder for you, and why?

6. On Sukkos the waters are poured out as a blessing. What worry could you turn into an offering?
7. Rabbi Eliezer says clouds of glory, Rabbi Akiva says real huts. What does each reading give your own sukkah?

GLOSSARY

Glossary

Short working definitions prepared for this booklet, as the terms are used in these readings.

Maamar. A formal Chassidic discourse, opened with a verse and said in a set way, usually at a farbrengen.

Sicha (pl. sichos). A talk of the Rebbe; many were later edited and printed, as in *Likkutei Sichos*.

Hanacha bilti mugah. A transcript written from memory by listeners and not edited by the Rebbe. Cite it as unedited.

Farbrengen. A Chassidic gathering with words of Torah, song and resolutions.

Kli. A vessel: whatever receives, holds and gives form to a higher light.

Bris (berit). Covenant: the binding bond between Hashem and Israel, and among the people under it.

Cherus. Freedom, in the Torah's sense of release for service, as against hefkerus, ownerless license.

Teshuvah. Return to Hashem; in Chassidus, the return of the soul to its root, higher than before the descent.

Yeridah tzorech aliyah. "Descent for the sake of ascent": a lowering whose purpose is a greater rise.

Mazal. In the maamar of 5743, a level above the ordered chain of worlds from which children, life and sustenance flow.

Hakhel. The gathering of the whole people every seventh year on Sukkos to hear the Torah read by the king.

Ger v'toshav. "Stranger and resident," Avraham's description of himself before the sons of Ches.

Kelipos. "Shells": the forces that conceal G-dliness.

Tohu and Tikkun. The world of chaos, of great lights in narrow vessels, which preceded the world of order.

Haftarah (pl. haftaros). The reading from the Prophets after the Torah reading on Shabbos and festivals, chosen to echo the parsha or the day.

Mefarshim. The classic commentators on the Torah, such as Rashi (1040–1105) and Ramban (1194–1270).

Keri and kesiv. Where the Masoretic text is read (keri) differently from how it is written (kesiv); the commentary sections quote the keri.

Malchiyos, Zichronos, Shofros. The three central blessings of the Musaf of Rosh Hashanah: kingship, remembrance and the shofar.

Nisuch hamayim. The pouring of water on the altar on each day of Sukkos, for the blessing of the year's rains.

Ananei hakavod. The Clouds of Glory that sheltered Israel in the desert; in the reading of Rabbi Eliezer (Sukkah 11b), the sukkah recalls them.

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Every outside work is credited to its author or publisher. Essays and notes by Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren are listed under his name. [to confirm] marks a detail not yet verified; [link to confirm] marks a link that did not load when checked on 10 November 2026. Where an item rests on only one source, the entry says so in plain words.

The Lubavitcher Rebbe: maamarim and sichos read in this booklet

The Lubavitcher Rebbe, Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson, *Likkutei Sichos*, vol. 30 (Bereishis), Vayechi, Sicha 1, pp. 236–240, adapted from the talk of Shabbat Parshat Vayechi 5746 (per the note at the end of the sicha), offprint issued for the hillula of Rachel Imeinu, Kehot Publication Society, Brooklyn, NY, volume published 1992 (per the Vaad L'hafotzas Sichos listing), https://store.kehotonline.com/prodinfo.asp?number=HRE-LS30; text online: https://pnimi.org/likutei-sichot-30-vayechi; Drive, Laptop Downloads 2026-11-06 folder (ID 1fNxl4_0JJ79V4poWB0eCONu1cg0X3sRW), inside the part01–part04 ZIP archives.

The Lubavitcher Rebbe, Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson, maamar *Lech Lecha* (ד"ה לך לך גו'), said at the farbrengen of Shabbat Parshat Lech Lecha, 10 MarCheshvan 5742, hanacha bilti mugah (unedited transcript), printed pp. סג–ס, offprint from Sefer HaMaamarim 5742 (forthcoming), issued for Shabbat Parshat Lech Lecha, 13 MarCheshvan 5787 (foreword dated 7 Cheshvan 5787), Sifrei Otzar HaChassidim, Lubavitch; prepared for print by Vaad Hanochos B'Lahak; Brooklyn, NY: Lahak Hanochos Inc., 2026 (5787) (copyright page); www.lahak.org [link to confirm]; Drive, Laptop Downloads 2026-11-06 folder (ID 1fNxl4_0JJ79V4poWB0eCONu1cg0X3sRW), inside the part01–part04 ZIP archives.

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